

GSS MUN 2025

CRISIS COMMITTEE

THE SILENT WAR

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Letter From the Dais

Dear Delegates,

Welcome to the United Nations Security Council at GSS MUN 2026, where the conflicts are quiet, the stakes are loud, and nothing is ever as simple as it looks. We're thrilled to have you here.

This committee is not about flashy wars with daily headlines or neatly defined battle lines. Instead, you'll be stepping into **"The Silent War"**, a space where crises unfold slowly, violence hides behind statistics, and decisions made (or avoided) shape the lives of millions long before the world starts paying attention. As representatives of the most powerful body within the United Nations, you are expected to debate, negotiate, strategize, and occasionally disagree, vigorously and creatively.

This year's agenda challenges you to confront instability that rarely dominates prime-time news but steadily erodes peace and security. Climate stress, fragile governance, proxy interests, and humanitarian collapse intersect in ways that demand more than recycled resolutions and safe diplomacy. These are conflicts defined not by a single trigger, but by years of neglect, miscalculation, and competing priorities. Quiet crises, after all, have a habit of becoming very loud if ignored for too long. Africa is often described as the cradle of humanity, yet it has also been burdened by centuries of extraction, interference, and oversimplification. In regions stretching across deserts, borders, and political fault lines, insecurity mirrors geography itself, harsh, expansive, and unforgiving. Your task is not merely to respond, but to understand: to look past symptoms and grapple with root causes, trade-offs, and unintended consequences.

There is much to be done, time is very much not on your side, and the room you're sitting in is designed to test exactly how far your diplomacy can stretch. The only question that remains is this: will you rise to the challenge, or quietly become part of the problem? (No pressure. Absolutely none.) Over the course of the committee, this study guide is meant to equip you, not hand you answers. We expect sharp debate, bold ideas, and above all, collaboration. Reform, restraint, realism, and responsibility will all be on trial as you attempt to adapt the Security Council to the messy realities of 21st-century conflict.

We're excited to see where you take this agenda. Let's make it intense, thoughtful, and just a little bit unforgettable.

Warm regards,

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I. Committee Overview

This committee is constituted as a high-level crisis body operating as an ad hoc session of the United Nations Security Council, convened to respond to rapidly unfolding, interconnected emergencies across the Equatorial African region and the Arabian Peninsula. Unlike standing UN organs with fixed mandates and predictable timelines, this committee exists only for the duration of the simulation, and it is designed to mirror the uncertainty, urgency, and political pressure that real decision-makers face when international peace and security are threatened. Delegates are therefore expected to act not as broad “country representatives” giving general policy statements, but as empowered state principals, leaders and senior officials who must authorize actions, make commitments, and accept trade-offs with immediate political, military, humanitarian, and strategic consequences.

The central objective of this committee is to ensure that delegates understand not only what they can do, but how decision-making works under crisis conditions. Information will be incomplete, time-sensitive, and at times contradictory; updates may represent intelligence reports, diplomatic cables, media coverage, NGO assessments, or battlefield developments, each with different reliability and political implications. Delegates must learn to interpret the “fog of crisis,” synthesize incoming developments quickly, and operate with a realistic balance of national interest, coalition-building, and collective security imperatives. This committee therefore prioritizes realism, adaptability, and decisiveness over overly rigid procedure, while still maintaining enough structure to keep debate productive and outcomes coherent.

In format, the body functions as a special summit-style, UNSC-adjacent crisis committee, distinct from standard General Assembly simulations and even from many conventional Security Council committees. It is not meant to be a forum for long-form rhetorical debate or purely declaratory diplomacy. Instead, it is an executive, action-oriented environment where the room is expected to generate responses that are operationally plausible, politically credible, and strategically sequenced. Delegates should assume that they are continuously managing escalation dynamics, where every move can trigger countermoves by rival states, regional actors, non-state groups, or domestic political forces. As in real crisis diplomacy, time spent speaking is valuable only insofar as it moves negotiations forward, signals intent credibly, or establishes leverage for concrete action.

Unlike General Assembly committees, where the usual rhythm is agenda-setting, general speakers’ list, moderated caucuses, working papers, and eventually a drafted resolution, this crisis committee operates under immediacy and disruption. Events outside the room actively shape what happens inside it, and the “agenda” may expand, shift, or split into multiple simultaneous emergencies. New crises may erupt without warning, existing conflicts may escalate or de-escalate unexpectedly, and actions taken by one delegate or bloc can create second- and third-order consequences across borders. In practical MUN terms, delegates should expect frequent pivots: a humanitarian emergency may suddenly become a maritime security issue; an insurgency may morph into a hostage crisis; a political collapse may trigger regional intervention and refugee outflows at the same time.

Accordingly, procedural rigidity is intentionally minimized to allow for fast negotiations, rapid authorizations, and continuous recalibration.

While the structure mirrors that of the Security Council, it is specifically adapted for crisis simulation and for the scenario region. Membership is deliberately limited to the P5 and selected Security Council members from Africa and the Middle East whose involvement is substantively relevant to the crises in question. This creates a focused, high-stakes environment in which every delegate's decisions carry disproportionate weight, and where coalition-building is both necessary and difficult. Importantly, while the committee retains Security Council gravitas, traditional veto mechanics will not apply in this simulation, meaning delegates cannot rely on procedural deadlock as a strategy. Instead, influence must be exercised through persuasion, bargaining, threat perception management, credible commitments, and coalition formation. In practice, this means the room rewards delegates who can craft workable compromises, assemble voting majorities, and design actions that others can realistically support, even if those actions are incremental or condition-based.

The mandate of the committee is broad but not unlimited, reflecting the Security Council's role in addressing threats to international peace and security. The committee is empowered to respond to crises involving political instability, armed conflict, terrorism and transnational militancy, state collapse, piracy and maritime insecurity, resource and border disputes, humanitarian catastrophes, mass displacement, and regional spillover effects across the Equatorial African belt and the Arabian Peninsula. Delegates may pursue political and diplomatic initiatives such as mediation frameworks, the appointment of envoys, the convening of emergency talks, the creation of contact groups, or backchannel engagement with key stakeholders. Delegates may also authorize security measures such as peacekeeping or peace enforcement concepts, counterterrorism coordination, embargoes, monitoring mechanisms, naval operations, evacuation planning, or targeted restrictions designed to deter escalation. Humanitarian measures, including aid corridors, protection arrangements for civilians, refugee management coordination, and structured engagement with relevant UN bodies and regional organizations, also fall within scope, particularly when instability creates urgent protection gaps.

The committee may further impose or lift sanctions, endorse transitional governance arrangements, authorize monitoring or verification mechanisms, condemn or deter spoilers, and respond collectively to violations of international peace. However, delegates should understand that "authority" here is not only a matter of what is theoretically permissible; it is shaped by political feasibility, operational capacity, legitimacy, and strategic coherence. In other words, the most successful delegates will not simply propose the most extreme action, they will propose the action that is credible, implementable, and likely to produce the intended effect under the constraints of international politics and the realities on the ground. Delegates must balance legality and legitimacy with practicality: a plan that is technically powerful but politically impossible will often collapse; a plan that is politically acceptable but operationally vague may fail to change realities. At the same time, this committee's authority is not absolute. It is not a court, and it does not adjudicate legal guilt or innocence. It cannot unilaterally abolish sovereignty, dissolve states, or mandate unrelated

domestic reforms absent a clear connection to international peace and security. Long-term development planning, purely internal policy debates, and broad social reconstruction programs generally fall outside the immediate remit unless they are directly tied to crisis stabilization or preventing imminent spillover. Delegates should therefore justify actions through a clear nexus to stabilizing security conditions, protecting civilians, preventing escalation, and restoring minimum conditions for peace.

Structure and Functioning of the Crisis Committee

The committee operates through a dynamic mix of formal debate, rapid negotiation, written action mechanisms, and continuous crisis updates, reflecting how real-world crisis diplomacy blends public positioning with private bargaining. Moderated debate and speakers' time remain useful for establishing national stances, introducing frameworks, building legitimacy for proposed action, and shaping the political narrative of the room. However, delegates should view formal speaking as a tool, not the end goal. Much of the committee's real work will occur through unmoderated caucuses, corridor diplomacy, bloc coordination, and direct negotiation, where text is drafted, coalitions are built, and trade-offs are made in real time. Beyond debates, chits will be highly recommended, beyond the other drafted documents, as a means for discourse and engagement in the committee. The committee's operational flow is anchored by three core crisis instruments.

1. Crisis updates function as the engine of realism: they deliver new intelligence, report consequences of previous actions, introduce unexpected developments, and force delegates to reassess strategy under pressure. Updates may include coups, attacks, humanitarian breakdowns, diplomatic shifts, military movements, or internal fractures within non-state groups. Delegates should assume that inaction is itself a decision; delays can allow adversaries to consolidate gains, civilians to be harmed, or political windows to close. In crisis MUN, staying ahead of the update cycle, anticipating escalation pathways and preempting them, is often the difference between control and chaos.
2. Communiqués represent collective or semi-collective political messaging intended to influence external audiences. These statements are not merely symbolic: in a crisis setting, signaling can deter escalation, reassure allies, delegitimize spoilers, encourage defections, shape media narratives, and affect the calculations of armed groups and regional actors. Communiqués can be issued by the whole committee, by blocs, or by coalitions, and their language matters: the difference between "condemn," "deplore," "call upon," or "demand," or between naming an actor versus describing them indirectly, can produce dramatically different reactions. Delegates should treat communiqués as strategic communication, timed, targeted, and aligned with actions taken elsewhere.
3. Substantive action is primarily executed through directives, which are concise, operational instructions submitted by individual delegations or coalitions to address specific elements of the crisis. Directives can include authorizing deployments, initiating negotiations, coordinating intelligence-sharing, requesting humanitarian access, sanctioning entities, establishing monitoring mechanisms, planning evacuations, or conducting maritime security

operations, provided these actions are plausible within a state's capabilities and the political constraints of the scenario. Directives are evaluated by the crisis staff based on feasibility, resources, timing, escalation risk, and likely reactions by other actors. Outcomes, successful, partially successful, or failed, will be reflected in subsequent updates, meaning every directive becomes part of an evolving action–reaction cycle.

Overall, the committee is designed to reward adaptability, strategic foresight, disciplined negotiation, and cooperative leadership under uncertainty. Success is not measured solely by producing documents or “winning” votes; it is measured by a delegation's ability to manage escalation, protect civilians, stabilize flashpoints, preserve regional security, and advance national and collective objectives without triggering uncontrollable blowback. Delegates should aim to build realistic coalitions, propose implementable measures, and remain responsive to the crisis arc, because in this committee, the situation will not wait for perfect consensus.

II. Introduction to the Agenda

Defining “The Silent War”

The phrase “Silent War” captures a pattern of conflict that rarely arrives in a single dramatic explosion, but instead accumulates through years of layered crises, fragmented violence, political shocks, economic unraveling, and humanitarian collapse, spilling across borders faster than the international community’s attention can track. In the Sahel, Sudan, the Congo, Yemen, and Somalia, armed actors compete for territory, legitimacy, and resources in environments where state institutions are contested, partially collapsed, or strategically hollowed out, and where civilians are forced to normalize insecurity as a permanent governing condition rather than a temporary emergency. These arenas are not isolated crises unfolding in parallel; they are interlinked nodes in a broader belt of instability shaped by cross-border militancy, climate stress, illicit markets, and foreign competition, dynamics that compound each other and create feedback loops of conflict reproduction. In IR terms, the “Silent War” is best understood not as a set of disconnected civil wars, but as a regionalized security complex where instability travels through shared borders, shared vulnerabilities, and shared external pressures.

This agenda is designed to push delegates beyond treating each country as a separate “case file,” because doing so obscures the ways contemporary conflict behaves like a system rather than an event. Modern conflict ecosystems are sustained through interacting political and material forces: a coup in one capital can reroute alliances, reshape recognition politics, and redirect arms and financing flows; a drought or failed rainy season can escalate competition over grazing routes and local governance, which armed groups then weaponize as recruitment narratives; a blockade, port disruption, or fuel shock can accelerate famine risk and collapse service provision; and the erosion of governance can turn humanitarian access into a battlefield tactic rather than a neutral relief mechanism. In these settings, violence is not merely the breakdown of order, it becomes a means of ordering: coercion substitutes for institutions, and armed actors increasingly function as political entrepreneurs. “Silent War,” therefore, is not a single war but a shared condition, where violence is continuous yet dispersed, accountability is scarce, sovereignty is contested in practice even when affirmed in principle, and international responses are repeatedly delayed until the costs are far higher than prevention would have been.

At its core, the term refers to conflicts that persist in plain sight yet remain chronically under-prioritized, under-resourced, and under-explained in global discourse. The “silence” is not the absence of violence, it is the absence of sustained political attention and strategic investment commensurate with the scale of suffering and destabilization. These conflicts often unfold as slow-burn instability rather than headline-grabbing turning points: shifting frontlines, recurring offensives, localized massacres, periodic ceasefires that collapse into renewed fighting, and cycles of retaliation that do not always produce one iconic moment that forces the world to focus. Their violence is frequently dispersed across rural areas, contested corridors, peripheral provinces, and borderlands where state presence is thin, visibility is limited, and reporting is dangerous, meaning entire

communities can endure years of insecurity without becoming a central feature of the international agenda. In practice, silence is produced when crises are treated as “chronic” rather than “urgent,” and when the global system calibrates intervention based on strategic value rather than human cost.

A defining feature of the Silent War is fragmentation, of actors, narratives, and responsibilities, which makes these conflicts resistant to simple solutions and easy moral binaries. Instead of two clearly defined sides, many of these theaters involve overlapping networks: state forces and splintered militaries; rebel coalitions with shifting internal alliances; extremist organizations operating through transnational corridors; clan militias and community defense groups; private military actors; and foreign-backed proxies whose support is shaped by regional rivalries and global competition. This layered complexity makes conflict difficult to summarize and even harder to mediate, and the world often defaults to simplified labels (“terrorism,” “civil war,” “tribal violence”) that flatten political realities and obscure underlying drivers such as the political economy of armed control, patronage networks, resource capture, and the legitimacy crisis of governance itself. The result is a crisis landscape where violence becomes normalized, humanitarian response becomes permanent rather than transitional, and “stability” is measured by whether catastrophe is merely slower, not whether peace is achievable. In IR terms, the Silent War persists because it reflects not only local collapse, but the strategic incentives of actors, domestic and external, who benefit from ambiguity, fragmentation, and the endurance of conflict as a manageable, profitable equilibrium.

Why These Conflicts Remain Overlooked

These crises remain overlooked in part because global attention is governed by fast, competitive media cycles and the political incentives that accompany them, cycles that tend to privilege conflicts that are visually dramatic, easily personalized, narratively binary, or directly connected to the immediate security and economic interests of major powers. The Silent War regions, stretching across the Sahel, Sudan, the Congo, Yemen, and Somalia, frequently generate stories that are structurally difficult to package into a clear, digestible storyline: multiple armed factions with shifting alliances, uncertain territorial control, contested information environments, and historical grievances that do not reduce neatly to “two sides.” When a conflict cannot be explained quickly, it is often explained less; when it is explained less, it becomes harder for publics and policymakers to sustain attention; and when attention fades, diplomacy becomes episodic rather than strategic. Over time, this produces a self-reinforcing invisibility loop: fewer headlines reduce political urgency, reduced urgency lowers policy prioritization, weaker prioritization constrains resources and coordination, instability worsens, and yet the crisis still fails to generate the kind of singular “breakthrough moment” that forces sustained international engagement. In IR terms, “neglect” is not accidental, it emerges from the interaction of information scarcity, agenda-setting power, and a global system that repeatedly triages crises according to perceived strategic value.

Practical barriers also contribute to this silence, especially through the politics of access and exposure. Many conflict zones are difficult or dangerous to enter due to active fighting, targeted

attacks on journalists and aid workers, landmines and ambush risks, bureaucratic restrictions, or deliberate obstruction by armed actors who benefit from opacity and plausible deniability. Where access is restricted, humanitarian data becomes thinner and slower, needs are undercounted, and atrocities are underdocumented, weakening both international urgency and the evidentiary foundations needed for credible accountability. Even when humanitarian agencies remain present, the operational reality is often one of negotiation under duress: access permissions can be revoked overnight, convoys can be taxed or diverted, and relief distribution can become entangled with local power structures. This creates a paradox where the very conditions that most demand international attention, high violence, state collapse, and civilian vulnerability, also generate the conditions that make sustained attention and reporting least feasible.

At the same time, donor fatigue is not merely a budgetary problem; it is a political economy of humanitarianism problem. When emergencies stretch from months into years, funding becomes harder to justify domestically for donor governments, especially when success is difficult to quantify and when domestic constituencies are focused elsewhere. Over time, assistance often shifts from ambitious stabilization, governance support, or long-term recovery toward bare-minimum life-saving operations, reinforcing a permanent “emergency management” model rather than conflict resolution. This is strategically significant: when humanitarian response becomes the main international tool, the global system may unintentionally adapt to crisis as a baseline condition, keeping populations alive without altering the structures that produce mass suffering in the first place. In practice, this can allow war economies and coercive political orders to persist, because external engagement becomes predictable, routinized, and risk-averse.

Geopolitical prioritization plays an equally significant role. Some crises are “overlooked” not because they are unimportant, but because they are inconvenient: they may expose the limits of international tools, require long-term investment that outlasts electoral cycles, or implicate external partners whose cooperation is desired on other strategic files. In a system where diplomatic attention is finite, issues compete for bandwidth, and conflicts that do not threaten major-power interests in an immediate or visible way are often treated as secondary, even when their human cost is catastrophic and their spillover risks are real. Moreover, global institutions tend to respond most decisively when major powers align; in the Silent War context, external actors frequently support different local partners, pursue competing security architectures, or hold incompatible priorities (counterterrorism vs. democratization, sovereignty vs. protection, stability vs. accountability). This undermines unified action and produces a familiar pattern: mandates that are politically constrained, diplomacy that is fragmented, and interventions that are reactive rather than preventive. The fragmentation of international will mirrors the fragmentation on the ground, producing responses that arrive late, operate in silos, and struggle to alter the underlying conflict trajectory even when they alleviate some immediate harm.

Core Agenda

To debate this agenda effectively, delegates should adopt a “multi-lens” approach. The Silent War cannot be solved through a single framework, counterterrorism alone cannot replace governance; humanitarian aid alone cannot stop armed recruitment; economic development alone cannot function where insecurity and corruption dominate. Each lens reveals different drivers, different victims, and different tools, and the most credible strategies are those that recognize tradeoffs while building coherence across security, humanitarian, governance, and economic objectives.

1. Through the security lens, delegates should assess how armed threats evolve: terrorist networks exploit ungoverned space, borderlands enable mobility, and coups disrupt command structures and alliances. But the security lens should not be limited to battlefield metrics; it must include how insecurity spreads through weapons trafficking, cross-border raids, and the emergence of “security markets” where protection is sold by whoever can enforce it. This lens also requires scrutiny of proxy involvement and external military partnerships, which can shift local power balances quickly, sometimes deterring violence in the short term while intensifying grievances and cycles of retaliation in the long term.
2. Through the humanitarian lens, the committee should examine how violence translates into human survival crises: displacement, famine risk, attacks on civilians, and the collapse of health and education systems. In Silent War contexts, humanitarian suffering is not merely a byproduct of war, it is often used as leverage. Siege tactics, aid diversion, restrictions on movement, and intimidation of humanitarian actors can become strategies to punish communities, fund armed groups, or reshape demographics. Delegates should therefore debate not only “how much aid,” but how to protect access, reduce manipulation, and prevent relief from becoming an incentive structure for war economies.
3. Through the governance lens, delegates must confront the central question of legitimacy: who is recognized as having the authority to govern, enforce law, and provide services? In many of these contexts, state capacity is uneven, strong in capitals, absent in peripheries, and institutions may be present in name but captured by patronage or coercion. Where governance fails, armed groups often fill the gap with parallel taxation, courts, and security arrangements. The governance lens pushes delegates to think in terms of institution-building, political inclusion, transitional arrangements, and credible pathways from conflict management to social contract restoration, even under crisis conditions.
4. Through the economic lens, delegates should see conflict as a system that produces profit and power. Resource extraction, smuggling routes, checkpoint taxation, fuel and food monopolies, ransom economies, and foreign currency capture can make war financially rational for elites and commanders. In such environments, peace efforts that ignore economic incentives often collapse, because they threaten livelihoods built on coercion. The economic lens therefore encourages delegates to consider targeted sanctions, supply chain transparency, border management, alternative livelihoods, and reconstruction plans that reduce the profitability of violence while enabling communities to survive without relying on armed protection networks.

Regional Conflict Overview

This section explains where the Silent War is happening and how these conflicts connect across borders, making them more than isolated national emergencies. By mapping the Equatorial and Sub-Equatorial conflict belt, it shows how geography (deserts, forests, maritime corridors), weak state reach, and transnational networks allow fighters, weapons, financing, and tactics to circulate across theaters, so instability “travels” even without formal interstate war. It also highlights why humanitarian conditions and security dynamics are inseparable at the regional level: displacement, market collapse, and blocked access do not just follow violence, they reshape who holds authority and resources. For delegates, this overview is important because it frames the crisis as a regional system with spillover, meaning any effective strategy must anticipate cross-border effects, coordinate among neighbors, and account for how external involvement and regional rivalries can escalate or contain conflict.

The Equatorial and Sub-Equatorial Conflict Belt

From the **Sahel stretching across Sudan into the Horn of Africa**, and from the **Great Lakes region of the Congo outward into neighboring states**, these crises form an interconnected belt where **geography, governance gaps, and transnational networks** interact to sustain instability. Vast borderlands, deserts, forests, and maritime corridors create spaces where state control is structurally difficult, terrain that limits surveillance, stretches security forces thin, and creates permissive environments in which non-state actors can **move, trade, recruit, and regroup** with relative resilience. In IR terms, these areas function as “semi-governed spaces,” where sovereignty exists formally on maps but is contested in practice, enabling armed groups to operate as both military challengers and political brokers. Many of these regions are also zones of intense demographic pressure and environmental volatility, where competition over land, water, grazing routes, and local political representation can escalate into violence, especially when armed groups supply the missing ingredients that transform grievance into organized conflict: **weapons, ideology, financing, and command structures**. The result is not simply insecurity, but the gradual emergence of conflict ecosystems where violence becomes routinized and governance becomes negotiated through force. This belt is not unified by ideology, but by shared structural conditions: **fragile institutions, contested legitimacy, and economies that can be captured through coercion**. What links these theaters is the way conflict becomes networked rather than purely territorial. Violence can “travel” through social, logistical, and economic channels even when it does not spread as a conventional invasion. Fighters migrate to new fronts in search of profit, protection, or patronage; tactics and propaganda diffuse across regions as groups imitate what works; arms and resources flow along smuggling routes that do not respect borders; and local crises become entry points for external actors seeking strategic footholds or influence over regional alignments. Delegates

should therefore approach these conflicts as part of a regional system, where stabilization in one area can reduce pressure elsewhere, and collapse in one area can generate cascading instability across multiple theaters, shifting burdens onto neighboring states and changing the strategic calculations of both regional and global actors.

Interconnected Security and Humanitarian Challenges

Security threats and humanitarian collapse reinforce each other in the Silent War, creating a mutually amplifying cycle that steadily undermines social resilience and state authority. Insecurity displaces communities, which weakens agricultural production, disrupts markets, and collapses public services, producing hunger, disease, and desperation. This desperation then increases vulnerability to armed recruitment, trafficking, and exploitation, especially among youth with limited alternatives, and among communities that perceive themselves as abandoned, marginalized, or persecuted. In many areas, displacement camps and informal settlements become both humanitarian lifelines and strategic terrain: spaces where control over food distribution, movement, and “protection” becomes a source of political power. In IR terms, the humanitarian arena becomes securitized, not only because aid workers operate in conflict zones, but because the flow of humanitarian resources can alter local power balances and shape political legitimacy. At the same time, humanitarian crises reshape conflict dynamics by changing who controls resources, credibility, and authority. When the state cannot deliver services, populations may depend on local powerbrokers, militias, or external patrons, effectively shifting the locus of governance away from formal institutions and toward armed intermediaries. When aid is delivered without security guarantees, it can be looted, taxed, or manipulated, becoming absorbed into war economies and patronage networks. When it is withheld, blocked, or bureaucratically restricted, famine risk rises and atrocities become easier to commit under cover of chaos, displacement, and informational blackouts. This creates a grim strategic logic: the worse the humanitarian situation becomes, the harder it is to negotiate peace, because conflict parties can weaponize suffering to gain leverage, reshape territorial control, or engineer demographic outcomes. Delegates should recognize that humanitarian breakdown is not merely an “effect” of war, it is often part of the bargaining landscape within which war is fought and peace is negotiated.

External Involvement and Regional Spillover Effects

External involvement in Silent War theaters often arrives in layered, overlapping forms: military assistance, drone support, training missions, arms supplies, private military contracting, diplomatic backing, and financial aid tied to strategic alignment. These interventions rarely remain neutral, because they inevitably interact with local legitimacy struggles and shift internal balances of power. Even when framed as counterterrorism or

stabilization, external support can embolden certain factions, deepen mistrust among communities that interpret foreign assistance as choosing winners, or incentivize armed actors to prolong conflict in the hope of securing external patronage. Meanwhile, rival external actors may back competing partners, turning local struggles into proxy arenas in which conflict becomes harder to resolve because incentives extend beyond national borders and into regional rivalries and global strategic competition. In IR terms, local conflict becomes “internationalized,” not necessarily through direct invasion, but through financing, recognition, and security partnerships that change the structure of bargaining and reduce the incentives for compromise. Spillover effects are among the most important reasons this agenda matters, because instability does not remain contained. It travels through refugees and IDPs crossing borders, through militant movement into neighboring states, through cross-border raids and retaliation, and through maritime insecurity that threatens trade routes and humanitarian supply chains. In the Sahel and Sudan, spillover can destabilize bordering governments, intensify communal conflicts, and stretch already-limited state capacity. In the Horn and Yemen, maritime and coastal insecurity affects international shipping lanes, regional economic stability, and the reliability of critical imports, including fuel and food. In the Great Lakes region, armed groups and political tensions can draw neighbors into cycles of intervention, suspicion, and retaliatory support for proxies, widening conflict even when no state formally declares war. Delegates should therefore consider responses that are not only country-specific but also regional, strengthening cross-border cooperation, shared early warning systems, coordinated humanitarian corridors, and frameworks that reduce incentives for destabilizing interference while recognizing that sovereignty, legitimacy, and security are deeply intertwined across this belt.

Thematic Analysis of the Silent War

This section explains what patterns repeatedly drive and sustain the Silent War across different countries, giving delegates a structured way to diagnose problems and craft policy tools. By focusing on themes, military coups, transnational terrorism, humanitarian crises and mass atrocity risks, proxy conflict dynamics, piracy in the Gulf of Aden, and failures of international attention, it identifies recurring mechanisms that reshape bargaining power, legitimacy, and incentives for violence. The value for debate is that themes help delegates move beyond “country descriptions” into policy-relevant causal analysis: how coups fracture institutions and invite external patronage; how terrorist ecosystems exploit borderlands and state overreaction; how starvation and displacement become instruments of coercion; how proxies prolong wars by raising the payoff of fighting; how maritime insecurity ties local collapse to global trade; and how international fragmentation produces reactive crisis management rather than durable settlement. In practical terms, this thematic lens encourages solutions that are transferable across cases, combining security, governance, humanitarian protection, and economic disruption of war systems, while still adapting to each theater’s unique actors and constraints.

Threats Posed by Military Coups

Coups are not merely leadership changes; they are structural shocks to the political and security architecture of the state, often producing cascading effects that outlast the takeover itself. In Silent War contexts, coups often emerge from real grievances, corruption, insecurity, public frustration, elite fragmentation, and perceptions of state failure, but they can generate outcomes that worsen long-term stability by weakening institutional legitimacy, narrowing political space, and politicizing the security sector. Militaries that seize power may consolidate control through repression, purge institutions, and concentrate decision-making in narrow circles, reducing transparency and eroding bureaucratic effectiveness. This weakens civilian governance and deepens mistrust between the state and society, particularly in peripheral regions where state presence is already contested. When elections are postponed, manipulated, or reduced to symbolic exercises, legitimacy erodes further, creating openings for armed groups to present themselves as protectors, alternative authorities, or “justice providers,” even when their governance is coercive. Coup dynamics also internationalize crises. They can trigger sanctions, diplomatic isolation, or suspension from regional bodies, which may reduce resources for governance and humanitarian response while simultaneously pushing juntas to seek alternative patrons, sometimes trading policy autonomy, resource concessions, or security alignment for regime survival. Internally, coups can fracture security forces into rival camps, disrupt chains of command, and fuel intelligence failures, creating opportunities for insurgent advances and widening insecurity in borderlands. For delegates, the key challenge is designing responses that deter unconstitutional seizures of power without collapsing state capacity or imposing collective costs on civilians, balancing democratic norms, stabilization imperatives, and the risk that punitive isolation accelerates fragmentation rather than restoring civilian rule.

Terrorism as a Transnational Threat

Terrorism in the Silent War is less a single organization than an adaptive ecosystem that evolves through opportunism, cross-border mobility, and exploitation of local political grievances. Armed extremist networks take advantage of porous borders, weak policing, marginalization, and governance vacuums to embed themselves within communities through coercion, ideology, protection rackets, and economic incentives. Rather than fighting conventionally, they often use asymmetric tactics, ambushes, IEDs, raids on villages, targeted assassinations, intimidation of local officials, to make governance appear impossible and provoke state overreaction. Overreaction can generate civilian harm, mass arrests, collective punishment narratives, and mistrust that becomes a recruitment multiplier. In IR terms, terrorism functions simultaneously as a security threat and a legitimacy contestation strategy, aimed at delegitimizing the state while presenting militants as inevitable or more

capable providers of order. Because these networks operate across borders, national responses alone are structurally insufficient. Yet regional cooperation is difficult where mistrust is high, where states prioritize regime survival over shared security, and where border regions are politically marginalized. Delegates should focus on strategies that combine security operations with governance restoration, community protection, and credible justice mechanisms, because purely kinetic approaches can suppress symptoms while leaving intact the enabling conditions that allow transnational militant ecosystems to regenerate: weak institutions, economic desperation, unresolved communal disputes, and the political exclusion that extremist groups strategically weaponize.

Humanitarian Crises and Allegations of Mass Atrocities

A core tragedy of the Silent War is that civilian suffering is not incidental, it is structural, recurrent, and frequently strategic. Attacks on villages, forced displacement, sexual violence, starvation tactics, and deliberate destruction of livelihoods can be used to punish communities, seize land, reshape demographic control, or terrorize populations into compliance. In these environments, allegations of mass atrocities emerge not only from battlefield violence but from systematic patterns: who is targeted, how displacement occurs, where violence is concentrated, and whether humanitarian assistance is intentionally obstructed or manipulated. Where access is restricted and documentation becomes thin, atrocity risks often grow “in the dark,” enabling impunity and delaying international response until the human cost becomes irreversible. This theme forces delegates to treat civilian protection as both an operational and political challenge: how to prevent harm in real time, how to document abuses credibly, and how to create deterrence when accountability is weak and impunity functions as a tool of power. Delegates should consider protective mandates, monitoring and verification mechanisms, humanitarian deconfliction, civilian early warning systems, and strategies that make protection commitments enforceable rather than rhetorical, while also recognizing that protection efforts can be politicized, resisted by armed actors, or undermined by external sponsors shielding partners from scrutiny.

Proxy Conflicts and Regional Rivalries

Proxy dynamics occur when external actors support local factions, directly or indirectly, to advance strategic goals such as influence, access, ideological competition, or containment of rivals. In Silent War theaters, proxy involvement can deliver rapid battlefield gains, but it often entrenches conflict by raising armed actors’ capacity to fight while lowering their incentives to compromise. External backing can also distort domestic legitimacy: leaders become more accountable to patrons than populations, and local political competition becomes a contest over external sponsorship rather than governance performance.

Negotiations become more fragile when external patrons prefer stalemate to compromise, treat the conflict as leverage in broader rivalries, or fragment peace processes by sponsoring parallel diplomatic tracks. In IR terms, proxy involvement can transform civil conflicts into arenas of competitive intervention where the bargaining space shrinks because external actors modify the cost-benefit calculus of war.

Delegates should treat proxy conflict as both a diplomatic and security challenge. Managing it may require regional frameworks, arms control measures, transparency commitments, negotiated limitations on foreign involvement, and incentive structures that reward de-escalation and political settlement. The central challenge is reducing the strategic payoff of prolonging conflict without producing security vacuums that civilians pay for.

Piracy in the Gulf of Aden

Piracy is often portrayed as simple criminality, but in Silent War contexts it reflects deeper governance failure, conflict spillover, and the expansion of maritime shadow economies. Coastal insecurity intensifies when economies collapse, maritime policing is weak, and armed groups or criminal networks exploit shipping routes and port infrastructure. Piracy can intersect with smuggling, weapons trafficking, and militant financing, turning the sea into an extension of war economies where coercion and profit reinforce each other. In some contexts, maritime insecurity becomes politically entangled, linked to local authority contests, protection rackets, and the strategic calculations of armed actors who benefit from disruption and the rents generated by insecurity. This theme connects the local to the global: disruptions at sea affect international trade, regional prices, insurance costs, and humanitarian supply chains. Delegates should consider maritime security coordination, coastal governance support, and economic alternatives for coastal communities, alongside the legal complexities of interdiction, detention, and prosecution, recognizing that durable reduction of piracy depends not only on naval patrols, but on weakening the land-based political and economic drivers that sustain maritime predation.

Failure of International Attention and Response

The Silent War persists partly because international responses are often reactive, fragmented, and constrained by short-term politics. Diplomatic initiatives may surge during crisis peaks and fade once headlines move on; peace processes may be under-resourced or poorly sequenced; humanitarian funding may spike and then decline; and security partnerships may focus narrowly on counterterrorism without building sustainable institutions, inclusive

governance, or legitimate justice systems. The result is a pattern of “management without resolution,” where external engagement aims to prevent total collapse rather than achieve durable peace, an approach that can inadvertently normalize chronic suffering as a permanent feature of the international system.

Delegates should treat the failure of attention as a political problem with strategic solutions: how to create sustained engagement despite media and electoral cycles, how to coordinate across institutions and donors, how to balance sovereignty with protection imperatives, and how to design interventions that remain credible even when attention shifts elsewhere. The committee’s challenge is to propose strategies resilient enough to endure political turnover, donor fatigue, and operational setbacks, while still delivering measurable improvements in security, humanitarian protection, governance legitimacy, and economic recovery.

Additional Themes to Consider

Beyond those provided above, the following themes matter because they help delegates move beyond describing violence and toward explaining why the conflict persists and how it escalates. In crisis committee terms, they function as your “diagnostic toolkit”: they reveal the structural incentives (profit, legitimacy, patronage, climate stress, information control) that shape actor behavior and determine whether interventions stabilize a situation or unintentionally worsen it. Keeping these themes in mind will allow delegates to craft directives that are not only reactive, but strategically designed to change incentives, prevent spillover, and reduce the long-term durability of conflict systems across different theaters.

- War Economies, Smuggling Networks, and Resource Capture

Across Silent War theaters, conflict persists because violence is often financially self-sustaining. Armed actors extract rents through checkpoints, illicit taxation, control of mines or fuel routes, kidnapping-for-ransom, and manipulation of aid flows. These war economies create powerful stakeholders in continued instability, making peace not only politically difficult but economically threatening to those who benefit from coercion. Delegates should consider tools that disrupt conflict financing while offering viable economic off-ramps, because if war remains profitable, armed actors will continually regenerate even after battlefield defeats.

- Information Warfare, Disinformation, and Narrative Legitimacy

In many Silent War contexts, control over information is a strategic asset. Armed groups, regimes, and external patrons compete to shape narratives about identity, legitimacy, atrocities, and foreign interference. Disinformation can inflame communal tensions, obscure accountability, and complicate humanitarian operations

by undermining trust. Delegates should recognize that “who is believed” can matter as much as “who is stronger,” and debate mechanisms for verification, strategic communication, and protection of civic space without enabling propaganda or censorship.

- Climate Stress as a Threat Multiplier

Environmental volatility, droughts, floods, desertification, and resource depletion, does not mechanically cause war, but it amplifies underlying governance and social tensions. Competition over water points, grazing corridors, and arable land can escalate into violence when institutions cannot mediate disputes and when armed groups exploit scarcity as a recruitment narrative. Delegates should treat climate stress as a conflict accelerator that intersects with governance failure, displacement, and food insecurity, requiring prevention strategies that link resilience-building with political settlement.

- Fragmented Governance and “Hybrid Authority”

A recurring feature of the Silent War is the emergence of hybrid governance, where authority is shared, often violently, between the formal state, local elites, militias, and armed groups. These actors may provide parallel courts, taxation, and security, creating a patchwork of rule that can appear stable while remaining coercive and brittle. Delegates should grapple with the political reality that rebuilding state legitimacy often requires negotiating with, or displacing, these hybrid authorities, balancing pragmatism with long-term institutional reconstruction.

Key Definitions

The following definitions provide the shared language delegates need to debate efficiently and precisely. Because Silent War crises involve complex actor networks, contested legitimacy, and overlapping humanitarian and security pressures, unclear terminology can lead to mismatched solutions and avoidable disagreement. These terms include:

- **Silent War:** Prolonged, underreported conflict ecosystems marked by fragmented actors, slow-burn instability, and chronic civilian harm driven by limited sustained international attention.
- **State capacity:** A state’s ability to enforce security, provide services, administer law, and collect revenue; often capital-centered and weak in peripheries in Silent War contexts.
- **Fragile state:** A state with weak institutions and limited ability to manage violence, deliver services, or maintain legitimacy.

- Legitimacy: Public acceptance of a government or authority as rightful; erodes through corruption, repression, poor service delivery, or unconstitutional power shifts.
- Governance vacuum: Areas where formal state authority is absent or ineffective, enabling alternative armed or informal rule.
- Hybrid authority: Shared or competing governance between the state and non-state actors (militias, clans, rebels) providing security, taxation, or justice.
- Political settlement: A negotiated distribution of power and resources that ends or manages conflict, often involving bargains among elites and armed actors.
- Non-state armed group (NSAG): Armed actor outside formal state command (rebels, militias, extremists, community defense forces) with mixed motives (ideology, profit, survival, grievance).
- Insurgency: Armed campaign to undermine or replace state authority, typically relying on mobility, local networks, and asymmetric tactics.
- Asymmetric warfare: Tactics used by weaker actors against stronger forces (ambushes, IEDs, hit-and-run attacks, targeted killings).
- War economy: Conflict-sustaining profit systems (smuggling, extortion, illicit taxation, resource capture, ransom, aid diversion) that incentivize continued violence.
- Illicit trafficking networks: Cross-border systems moving arms, drugs, people, gold/minerals, or fuel that finance armed actors and weaken governance.
- Aid diversion: Redirection of humanitarian assistance by armed or political actors for profit, control, or leverage.
- Displacement: Forced movement caused by conflict or crisis: IDPs (within borders) and refugees (cross borders), reshaping security, aid needs, and governance.
- Humanitarian access: Safe, impartial ability for aid to reach civilians; commonly obstructed by insecurity, bureaucracy, or deliberate manipulation by armed/political actors.
- Humanitarian corridor: A negotiated route or zone intended to allow civilian movement and aid delivery, often requiring guarantees from conflict parties.
- Mass atrocities: Large-scale or systematic violence against civilians that may constitute war crimes, crimes against humanity, or genocide; implies urgent protection and accountability needs.
- Accountability mechanisms: Processes that investigate, document, and punish abuses (domestic courts, international courts, sanctions, monitoring bodies).
- Proxy involvement: External actors backing local factions with money, arms, training, intelligence, or diplomacy to advance broader strategic interests, often prolonging conflict.
- Conflict spillover: Cross-border spread of instability via refugees, arms flows, militant movement, raids, or economic disruption.
- Regional security complex: A cluster of states whose security problems are so interconnected that they cannot be analyzed or resolved separately.
- Maritime insecurity: Threats at sea (piracy, smuggling, attacks on shipping) that disrupt trade and humanitarian supply chains.

III. Specific Agenda Breakdown

In the section below, this study guide moves from the “big picture” framework established in Section II into the concrete, actionable substance of committee work. III. Specific Agenda Breakdown is designed to map out the exact crisis domains that will define debate, negotiation, and decision-making throughout the simulation. Each agenda area is not presented as an isolated topic, but as a component of a larger crisis ecosystem, meaning developments in one area may directly trigger escalation, spillover, or opportunity in another. Because this is a crisis committee, delegates should treat these agenda components as simultaneous operational lanes that will often run in parallel: while one bloc negotiates de-escalation in a maritime flashpoint, another may be coordinating humanitarian access, and a third may be responding to state collapse dynamics or transnational militant activity.

It is also important to acknowledge the level of detail you will see below. At first glance, it may seem unusually expansive for a committee that will run for only three days. However, that detail is intentional and practical. Crisis simulations do not progress like traditional committees; they move quickly, with multiple issues evolving at once, and they require delegates to make decisions with imperfect information and limited time. A more detailed agenda breakdown does not mean the committee must “finish” every issue in a linear way, instead, it ensures that delegates have enough structure to act decisively without constantly waiting for clarification on what falls within scope. It also allows crisis staff to escalate events logically and consistently, because the committee has a defined set of crisis arenas to engage with from the start.

A. Instability in the Sahel Region

Background and Current Situation

The Sahel is best understood not as a collection of separate national emergencies, but as a single, interlinked security–humanitarian theater stretching across a semi-arid belt that connects West and Central Africa and bleeds into North Africa. What makes the Sahel distinct is the way geography and governance interact: vast distances, porous borders, sparse state presence outside capitals, and communities whose livelihoods and identities have always been transnational. In practice, this means violence and instability do not “stay put” inside one country’s borders. Armed groups move across frontiers to evade pressure, traffickers reroute around new checkpoints, and displaced populations follow kinship networks and safer corridors regardless of state lines. The region’s crises therefore behave less like isolated fires and more like a wind-driven blaze, when one area collapses, the heat, smoke, and embers spread into neighboring states. This is also why Sahel crises routinely trigger “spillover” effects that become internationalized: refugee inflows, cross-border raids, and rising regional insecurity that draws in external counterterrorism and stabilization agendas.

This connectivity is intensified by cross-border mobility of fighters, weapons, and illicit economies. Extremist networks and community militias often recruit locally but sustain themselves regionally, drawing on smuggling routes, ransom markets, taxation of trade, and exploitation of resource corridors. Meanwhile, state security forces, often unevenly trained, underpaid, and mistrusted, struggle to maintain territorial control and civilian protection simultaneously. The result is a reinforcing cycle: insecurity reduces state reach; reduced state reach increases the space for armed actors; armed actors then become the de facto authorities in some areas, shaping who can travel, trade, farm, or access aid. In many locales, “authority” is not a single institution but a negotiated reality, armed groups, customary leaders, and local administrations each claim portions of governance, making compliance and survival depend on navigating overlapping rule systems rather than obeying one state.

A critical part of framing the Sahel is its regional security architecture, which sits at the intersection of sovereignty and collective action. Sahelian states frequently emphasize non-interference and territorial integrity, especially when facing legitimacy challenges at home. At the same time, regional and international bodies argue that cross-border threats require shared responses, intelligence cooperation, joint operations, sanctions, mediation, and humanitarian coordination. This creates constant tension over who has the authority to act, what counts as lawful assistance, and how to weigh immediate security needs against the long-term political legitimacy required for stability. In committee, delegates should treat sovereignty not as a trump card but as a contested concept: governments invoke it to limit external pressure, while others invoke collective security and regional norms to justify intervention, sanctions, or conditional recognition. This tension is not abstract; it shapes mandates and partnerships, including debates over host-state consent in peace operations, the legality and oversight of foreign security assistance, and whether regional bodies should treat coups primarily as security problems or as violations of constitutional order.

The present crisis is the outcome of a long sequence in which governance breakdown, insurgency, and military takeovers repeatedly reinforce one another. Across parts of the Sahel, civilian governments have faced declining public trust due to corruption perceptions, weak service delivery, contested elections, and inability to protect communities from violence. As attacks expanded from remote peripheries toward towns, highways, and strategic economic areas, civilians increasingly judged governments by the most basic metric: whether the state could keep them alive and provide minimal stability. When that expectation failed, especially after high-profile massacres, military losses, or visible territorial erosion, security forces and political opponents often framed civilian leadership as incapable or illegitimate, creating fertile ground for coups and emergency rule. The international legal and diplomatic stakes then rise quickly: unconstitutional changes of government trigger regional sanctions regimes and recognition dilemmas, while counterterrorism imperatives can tempt external actors to prioritize “security partners” over democratic legitimacy.

Military takeovers can initially appear “stabilizing” because they promise decisive action. In practice, however, coups often deepen the very drivers they claim to solve. They disrupt chains of command, politicize promotions, fragment security services, and shift priorities toward regime survival rather

than community protection. International partnerships can be strained or rerouted, sometimes replaced with new external security arrangements that provoke controversy at home and abroad. Meanwhile, governance capacity rarely improves quickly: ministries lose expertise, budgets become opaque, and local administration continues to shrink where insecurity is greatest. This combination, greater coercive ambition with weaker civilian institutions, tends to increase human rights risks, fuel grievances, and expand recruitment opportunities for insurgents. Where repression rises and accountability falls, violence becomes easier to justify in the language of “state security,” even as it erodes the legitimacy that counterinsurgency requires to be effective.

The current situation is also defined by displacement patterns and humanitarian stress. When armed groups contest territory, civilians often face a brutal menu of choices: flee, comply, or resist and risk retaliation. Displacement is rarely a single movement; it is repeated, layered, and strategic, families move to nearby towns, then to camps, then across borders, then back again if conditions shift. As public services collapse in contested areas, schools close, clinics run out of staff and medicines, and markets become dangerous or controlled by armed actors. Humanitarian access becomes a political and security problem at the same time: aid requires consent and coordination, but in many places the state cannot guarantee safety, and armed groups seek to influence distribution to build legitimacy or extract resources. This is where international humanitarian law principles, distinction, precaution, and the protection of civilians, intersect with practical realities: even when norms are clear, implementing them is difficult in fragmented conflicts where “frontlines” are fluid and armed actors embed themselves in civilian environments.

Legitimacy and representation questions then become unavoidable. Who speaks for the state when civilian governments are deposed? Who has the authority to consent to foreign deployments, sign agreements, or commit to transitional timelines? International forums may seat one set of authorities, while domestic opposition and parts of the population reject them. This ambiguity shapes everything from sanctions policy to peace talks, and it directly affects whether humanitarian actors can operate impartially or are pulled into accusations of “supporting” one side. It also complicates treaty-based cooperation: extradition, intelligence sharing, and mutual legal assistance often rely on recognized governmental counterparts, but recognition becomes politically contested precisely when insecurity is highest.

Delegates should map actors by capability and incentives: who can deliver security, who can block political transitions, who controls territory, and who influences public opinion. On the state side, military governments often hold coercive power in capitals and along strategic corridors, but their reach into peripheral zones can be limited or contested. Civilian opposition movements may possess urban mobilization capacity, international advocacy networks, and legitimacy claims, yet they may struggle to affect conditions where violence is concentrated. Neighboring states matter not only as diplomatic players but also as logistical gateways, borders determine supply routes, refugee flows, and the ability of armed groups to regroup. In practice, “regional states” may simultaneously cooperate on paper while competing in influence operations, border policies, and patronage networks that shape which armed actors gain breathing room.

Regional bodies and external partners operate as force multipliers and legitimacy brokers. Their influence can come through recognition decisions, sanctions, mediation frameworks, security assistance, and funding streams. However, these actors also compete with one another, and their strategies can clash: some prioritize counterterrorism cooperation, others prioritize constitutional order and civilian rule, and others prioritize migration control or resource security. Humanitarian agencies operate with different incentives, access, neutrality, life-saving priorities, but they become politically relevant because they may be the only visible “service providers” in many areas. The UN system adds further complexity: Security Council mandates, sanctions regimes, and peacekeeping principles can pull in different directions, especially when the same state is both a counterterrorism partner and a site of serious allegations of civilian harm.

On the non-state side, the Sahel features a spectrum from community self-defense groups to organized extremist networks. Community militias may form around protection needs, ethnic or local identity, and retaliation dynamics; they can be both a shield and a source of abuse. Extremist groups often function as insurgent governance entrepreneurs: they provide rough dispute resolution, impose taxes, enforce social rules, and exploit grievances against state forces or rival communities. Private security actors and foreign military contractors can further complicate the landscape by changing local balances of power while raising questions about oversight and accountability. The political economy matters here: armed actors rarely survive on ideology alone, they survive because they embed into local economies, regulate trade, and position themselves as arbiters of daily life where the state is absent or predatory.

Engagement with non-state armed groups is one of the most sensitive dilemmas. Negotiation may be framed as pragmatic de-escalation or as unacceptable legitimization of violence. Even humanitarian contact, necessary for access, can be mischaracterized as political support. Meanwhile, accountability actors such as commissions of inquiry, domestic courts, and international mechanisms influence incentives by raising the potential cost of atrocities, but they can also make leaders reluctant to compromise if they fear future prosecution. Delegates should recognize that “who can sign” is not the same as “who can implement”: deals that ignore local power-holders and armed gatekeepers often fail on the ground. This is a central lesson of many Sahel peace and stabilization attempts, implementation hinges on local security guarantees, credible monitoring, and economic arrangements that reduce the incentives for armed entrepreneurship.

Political fragility is the foundation upon which the Sahel’s insecurity grows. Legitimacy crises, driven by disputed elections, exclusionary politics, corruption narratives, and perceived abandonment of peripheral communities, create conditions where armed actors can present themselves as alternatives. When civilians see the state as predatory, absent, or aligned with one community against another, they may tolerate or even support non-state actors out of fear or perceived necessity. Military takeovers often intensify these legitimacy disputes by narrowing political space, suppressing dissent, and creating governance that is strong in coercion but weak in trust. Over time, this erodes the social contract: the state becomes an armed actor among others rather than a neutral provider of protection and services.

Security drivers are equally reinforcing. A security vacuum emerges where the state cannot patrol, hold territory, or protect civilians, but attempts to fill that vacuum through aggressive counterinsurgency can backfire if operations produce civilian harm, arbitrary detention, or collective punishment. These abuses become propaganda for insurgents and deepen local grievances. Fragmentation within security forces, between army units, police, intelligence services, and auxiliary militias, creates competing chains of command and inconsistent behavior, which erodes public confidence and increases the risk of localized warlordism. Where oversight is weak, “security provision” can transform into predation, extortion at checkpoints, abuse in detention, or selective protection, fueling the very grievances extremist recruiters exploit.

Economic drivers include the power of illicit economies that thrive in weakly governed spaces. Smuggling networks, moving fuel, arms, people, and contraband, often provide income and protection arrangements that tie together local elites, armed groups, and sometimes corrupt state officials. Where livelihoods are fragile, these networks can look like opportunity, and armed groups can tax or control them to finance operations. This connects directly to transnational organized crime and terrorism financing dynamics: money flows do not respect borders, and policy responses (asset freezes, targeted sanctions, border controls) can be effective but also disruptive if they choke local economies without alternatives. In committee terms, delegates should treat “illicit economies” not as a side issue but as a backbone structure, if revenue streams remain intact, armed groups remain resilient regardless of battlefield losses.

Social and environmental pressures sharpen the conflict edge. Climate variability, land degradation, and competition over pasture and water intensify disputes among farmers, pastoralists, and mixed communities, especially where traditional dispute mechanisms have weakened and the state is absent. Ethnic polarization often follows, with armed groups recruiting along identity lines and political actors exploiting fear to mobilize support. Misinformation and rumor, amplified by social media and word-of-mouth, can trigger panic, retaliation, and scapegoating, particularly after attacks when communities search for someone to blame. The interaction effect is key: environmental stress alone does not cause insurgency, but it magnifies the consequences of weak governance, unequal access to justice, and the availability of armed protection markets.

A wide range of efforts have been attempted, and a key purpose of this section is to show why many “standard templates” fail in the Sahel. Security coalitions and joint force initiatives have aimed to coordinate counterterrorism operations, share intelligence, and secure borders. Yet coordination problems, funding gaps, mistrust among partners, and divergent national priorities often limit effectiveness. Peace missions and stabilization operations have tried to protect civilians and support political processes, but they face constraints: host-state consent can become politicized, impartiality becomes difficult when governments are themselves parties to conflict, and mandates can be stretched between counterterrorism and civilian protection in ways that satisfy neither. This is also where debates about international law and mandate design become operational: whether a mission is authorized under UN Charter principles, how rules of engagement are set, and how civilian harm mitigation is enforced can determine whether an intervention stabilizes or inflames.

Political roadmaps, transitional timelines, constitution-making promises, and election pledges, frequently stall because the incentives of coup authorities differ from the incentives of external stakeholders. Military rulers may view rapid transitions as existential threats, while opposition groups may reject timelines they see as manipulated. Disarmament, demobilization, and reintegration (DDR) attempts often falter when they treat armed actors as a uniform category rather than a web of local interests; reintegration fails when there are no jobs, no security guarantees, and no trusted institutions to absorb former fighters. In practice, DDR without parallel security sector reform and local reconciliation can simply reshuffle armed actors, creating new “eligible” beneficiaries while leaving grievance structures and coercive networks untouched.

Sanctions and diplomatic pressure have been used to deter unconstitutional changes of government and incentivize transitions, but they can have mixed results. Targeted sanctions may isolate leaders while limiting humanitarian spillover, yet they can also harden positions and push authorities toward alternative external patrons. Comprehensive measures can cause civilian suffering and fuel nationalist narratives that delegitimize external actors. Mediation efforts sometimes succeed at producing agreements on paper, but implementation collapses when deals do not address local power realities, community security needs, and the economic structures that sustain armed groups. The consistent committee takeaway is that durable stabilization requires sequencing: security measures that reduce immediate violence, governance measures that rebuild legitimacy, and economic measures that undercut armed revenue, because if any one pillar is pursued in isolation, the conflict ecosystem adapts and survives.

Key Points of Contention and Takeaways

Committee conflict will likely crystallize around recognition and legitimacy: whether coup authorities should be treated as de facto governments, whether seating and engagement confer legitimacy, and what conditions, if any, should be required for acceptance. This is not just diplomatic symbolism; it determines who can lawfully consent to foreign deployments, sign security agreements, and receive international financing. Delegates will likely invoke competing legal and normative frames: strict sovereignty and effective control on one side, versus anti-coup norms embedded in African regional practice on the other (notably the AU’s anti-unconstitutional change of government stance reflected in the Lomé Declaration and the African Charter on Democracy, Elections and Governance, alongside ECOWAS’ 2001 Protocol on Democracy and Good Governance). In practical terms, legitimacy disputes also decide whether mediation platforms treat military rulers as transitional caretakers, or as illegitimate usurpers who must be pressured out.

Delegates will also clash over foreign military presence. Some will argue that external forces are necessary to prevent state collapse and contain cross-border terrorism; others will argue that foreign deployments provoke backlash, undermine sovereignty, and entrench cycles of violence, especially if oversight is weak or civilian harm occurs. This debate often turns on authorization: multilateral mandates (e.g., UN peace operations such as MINUSMA, established by Security Council

Resolution 2100 (2013)) versus bilateral invitations and ad hoc coalitions. It also turns on strategy: whether counterterrorism partnerships prioritize short-term disruption of armed groups, or long-term political settlement and civilian protection. Real-world examples matter here: when populations perceive foreign forces as unaccountable, politically biased, or culturally hostile, armed actors can frame themselves as “resistance,” widening recruitment beyond their original base.

Sanctions versus stability is another dividing line. One bloc may prioritize enforcing regional norms against unconstitutional seizures of power, viewing sanctions as essential deterrence; another bloc may prioritize immediate security imperatives, arguing that pressuring regimes risks worsening insecurity and humanitarian conditions. Delegates should also distinguish between types of pressure: targeted travel bans and asset freezes on coup leaders versus broad economic measures that can boomerang onto civilians. This is where committee dynamics get sharp: some actors will insist that “no consequences” invites a coup cascade, while others will argue that isolating authorities pushes them toward alternative patrons and reduces cooperation on border security, migration management, and counterterrorism. Underneath the rhetoric is a credibility problem, if sanctions are declared but not enforced consistently, they become performative and lose deterrent value.

Counterterror tactics will be contested as well: robust kinetic operations may promise short-term disruption of armed groups, but they raise the risk of abuses and long-term radicalization if civilian protection is not central. Delegates should treat this as a core IR dilemma, security-first versus legitimacy-first, and remember that counterterrorism law and humanitarian law constraints are not optional extras. The UN Global Counter-Terrorism Strategy (A/RES/60/288) explicitly links counterterrorism effectiveness to human rights compliance, and the broader post-9/11 framework (including Security Council Resolution 1373 (2001)) created obligations that can be implemented responsibly or abusively. In Sahel practice, heavy-handed raids, mass detention, or collective punishment can produce tactical “success” while strategically expanding grievance and insurgent influence.

Civilian protection and humanitarian access will create both moral and operational disagreement. Some delegates will emphasize strict neutrality and humanitarian carve-outs; others will worry that aid can be diverted, taxed, or used to strengthen armed groups. This is not hypothetical: where armed groups operate as gatekeepers, aid can become a revenue stream or a legitimacy tool. Delegates may anchor arguments in humanitarian norms, particularly the coordinating principles set out in UNGA Resolution 46/182 (humanity, neutrality, impartiality, independence), but will disagree on how those principles survive contact with real power. Aid conditionality will also be contested: tying assistance to governance reforms might incentivize better behavior, but it can also punish civilians and reduce access if authorities retaliate or restrict humanitarian actors. Finally, external security assistance raises questions about legality and legitimacy, whether consent is valid under contested regimes, how accountability is enforced, and who bears responsibility when partner forces commit violations. These debates will naturally pull in the Geneva Conventions and customary IHL obligations on protecting civilians, as well as the human-rights baseline that applies to state security forces even during counterinsurgency.

Any credible strategy must begin with the legal and political basis for action, because “doing something” without a recognized foundation will fracture coalitions and undermine implementation. Delegates must decide whether the committee’s approach relies primarily on multilateral authorization (UN Charter-based mandates, Security Council-backed missions, sanctions regimes), regional mechanisms (AU/ECOWAS frameworks, regional mediation and enforcement), or bilateral host-state consent, and how to handle the legitimacy problem if the host authority is contested. From there, the strategy must address a persistent contradiction: counterinsurgency often demands force, but force without safeguards produces abuses that fuel insurgency. Delegates need concrete mechanisms, oversight, reporting, training, accountability triggers, and civilian harm mitigation, to prevent the security response from becoming a recruitment engine for armed groups. In committee terms, this is where vague “capacity-building” must become operational: who monitors, what gets reported, what triggers suspension of assistance, and what happens when violations occur.

Transition legitimacy is the other non-negotiable. Delegates must determine what “credible transition” actually means in practice: election sequencing, constitutional reforms, inclusion of marginalized communities, protection of opposition space, and monitoring arrangements that can be trusted. A rushed vote without security and legitimacy can spark further crisis; an open-ended transition can entrench military rule. The committee should push delegates to articulate enforceable milestones rather than rhetorical commitments, e.g., timelines tied to benchmarks on political freedoms, electoral administration independence, and localized security arrangements that make participation possible outside capitals. The key takeaway is that “elections” are not automatically legitimacy; legitimacy is produced when rules are credible, participation is meaningful, and losers believe the process was fair enough to accept.

Finally, humanitarian access must be treated as both a principled obligation and a strategic necessity. If civilians cannot access food, medicine, and safety, instability becomes permanent. Delegates must propose practical access arrangements that protect neutrality while recognizing the reality of armed control over territory. This includes thinking through how to coordinate with local actors without empowering them, how to prevent aid diversion (verification, community-based targeting, anti-corruption safeguards), and how to ensure that humanitarian corridors do not become battlegrounds (deconfliction channels, publicly communicated protections, and consequences for interference). In the Sahel context, the strongest plans will be those that link these issues together, security that protects civilians, governance that rebuilds legitimacy, and humanitarian action that stabilizes communities, because any approach that treats them separately will fail under the region’s deeply interconnected pressures.

B. Extremist Violence in Nigeria

Background and Current Situation

Extremist violence in Nigeria persists not because the state has been absent from the problem, but because military campaigns alone have struggled to dismantle the underlying ecosystem that sustains armed groups. The conflict is most acutely concentrated in the northeast, particularly Borno, Yobe, and Adamawa states, yet its effects radiate outward through porous borders and economic corridors into the wider Lake Chad Basin (Cameroon, Chad, and Niger). Over time, armed factions, notably Boko Haram and the Islamic State West Africa Province (ISWAP), have adapted to pressure by dispersing into hard-to-govern terrain, embedding themselves in rural communities, and shifting tactics between territorial control, guerrilla raids, ambushes on security forces, kidnappings, and attacks designed to maximize fear rather than hold ground. This adaptability means that “success” in one operational zone can simply displace violence into another, creating the illusion of progress while insecurity mutates rather than disappears. It also explains why Nigeria’s challenge is simultaneously domestic and regional: armed actors exploit borders for sanctuary, logistics, recruitment, and financing, making purely national solutions structurally incomplete.

Recruitment conditions remain central to understanding why the violence renews itself. Armed groups draw strength from a combination of coercion and opportunity: forced recruitment exists, but so does voluntary enlistment driven by unemployment, insecurity, lack of education, and grievances against local governance. In areas where state presence is thin or experienced mainly through checkpoints, arrests, or heavy-handed raids, extremist groups exploit narratives of injustice and abandonment. They present themselves as providers of protection, income, or belonging, especially for youth who perceive no viable future. Patterns of attacks often reflect this logic: strikes on villages can punish perceived collaboration; attacks on military bases can demonstrate strength; kidnappings and taxation of trade can fund operations; and assaults on roads can sever economic lifelines, intensifying poverty and food insecurity that in turn feed further instability. Delegates should also note the “governance competition” dynamic: when armed groups can settle disputes, regulate markets, and enforce rules (however coercively), they start to look like an alternative authority in spaces where the state is inconsistent.

State presence gaps are not only about troop numbers but about governance density. Many communities experience “security” as intermittent patrols rather than reliable protection, and “government” as distant authorities rather than functioning services. When schools close, clinics collapse, and markets become unsafe, civilian life contracts into survival mode, and displacement becomes both a symptom and a driver of insecurity. Camps for internally displaced persons (IDPs) can become crowded pressure points where hunger, trauma, and exploitation increase vulnerability, especially when access is constrained by insecurity or when movement restrictions cut people off from livelihoods. The result is a feedback loop: violence causes displacement and food insecurity; displacement and food insecurity deepen desperation and weaken community resilience; weakened resilience makes recruitment and control easier for armed groups. This is why humanitarian policy is not separate from security policy in Nigeria’s northeast, it is part of the conflict’s structural terrain.

From a legal and policy perspective, the counterterrorism response sits at the intersection of domestic law and international standards. Detention practices, screening operations, prosecutions,

and the handling of suspected child recruits raise questions of due process and fair trial rights (ICCPR standards), as well as child protection obligations (CRC and its Optional Protocol on the involvement of children in armed conflict). The treatment of IDPs also implicates binding regional commitments, including the Kampala Convention (African Union Convention for the Protection and Assistance of Internally Displaced Persons). A key analytical hinge is whether and when the violence meets the threshold of a non-international armed conflict (NIAC). That classification matters because it changes the framework of obligations: once violence reaches sufficient intensity and organization, Common Article 3 of the Geneva Conventions and (where applicable) Additional Protocol II become central for conduct of hostilities, humane treatment, and protections for civilians. For delegates, this is not a technical footnote, it is the foundation for deciding what measures are lawful, what measures are effective, and what measures might fuel the very insurgency they aim to defeat. It also connects to the UN's counterterrorism architecture: Security Council Resolution 1373 (2001) created broad counterterrorism obligations, while later resolutions (e.g., 2178 (2014) on foreign terrorist fighters and 2396 (2017) on returning fighters and border measures) push states to strengthen enforcement, but those tools can either reinforce legitimacy or undermine it depending on safeguards and accountability.

The Nigerian conflict landscape is less a simple "government versus insurgents" contest and more a crowded security ecosystem where multiple armed and civilian-facing actors interact, overlap, and sometimes contradict one another. Nigerian security forces, including the military, police, intelligence services, and specialized counterterror units, remain the central state instruments, but they operate under immense strain: resource constraints, difficult terrain, civilian mistrust, and the constant challenge of distinguishing fighters from non-combatants in areas where armed groups blend into daily life. Regional partners and joint border arrangements matter because armed factions exploit cross-border sanctuaries and logistical routes, making purely national solutions inherently limited. This is where the Multinational Joint Task Force (MNJTF) and Lake Chad Basin cooperation become strategically relevant: they aim to reduce "safe haven effects," but they also raise coordination problems, different rules of engagement, uneven capacities, and political incentives that do not always align.

Alongside formal forces, vigilante and community self-defense groups have become influential actors in many areas, often emerging because communities feel unprotected and must fill the gap themselves. These groups can provide local intelligence, early warning, and community defense, but they also introduce serious problems of accountability and command-and-control. When armed civilians operate with unclear oversight, their actions can escalate inter-communal violence, enable abuse, or deepen cycles of retaliation, especially if they are perceived as aligned with one identity group against another. This makes them simultaneously potential partners and potential spoilers, depending on how they are integrated, regulated, or confronted. In committee terms, this becomes a design question: whether to formalize them under strict regulation and training, demobilize them through community security programs, or limit their role to unarmed early-warning and civil protection functions.

On the extremist side, factions may share ideological roots but differ in leadership structures, tactical preferences, and relationships with local populations. Some emphasize coercion and spectacular violence; others prioritize sustained influence through taxation, “justice” systems, and selective violence that pressures communities without constant mass attacks. Their rivalry and fragmentation complicate negotiation, ceasefires, and deradicalization efforts because “the enemy” is not always a single chain of command. Humanitarian agencies and local civil society organizations operate in this environment as essential civilian-facing actors, often the only institutions consistently delivering services, yet they face threats from armed groups, suspicion from authorities, and operational limits that shape what aid can reach and how. This is also where misinformation becomes operational: rumors of bias, diversion, or “collaboration” can endanger aid workers, distort targeting, and fracture community cohesion.

The legal/policy lens here is crucial: protection of civilians is not a discretionary preference that can be sidelined in emergencies, it is a core duty of state authorities and a strategic necessity for breaking recruitment cycles. When civilians experience security forces as protectors rather than predators, intelligence improves, community cooperation increases, and extremist narratives lose potency. When civilians experience security forces as arbitrary or abusive, armed groups gain a recruitment advantage. Delegates should treat civilian protection as the connective tissue linking operational success to political legitimacy. This framing also aligns with the logic behind UN stabilization and peacebuilding approaches (including the emphasis on sustaining peace in Security Council/General Assembly Resolution 2282 (2016)): security gains that do not translate into trust and services rarely endure.

Extremist violence in Nigeria is sustained by a layered set of drivers that military force can suppress but rarely resolves on its own. Unemployment and underemployment, especially among youth, intersect with educational disruption and weak local economies to produce a pool of people for whom armed group recruitment can appear as the only path to income, status, or survival. Local grievances add depth to this vulnerability: perceptions of corruption, unequal distribution of resources, abusive policing, or favoritism by local elites create resentment that extremists can weaponize. Where communities feel excluded from decision-making or treated as suspects rather than citizens, the social contract erodes, and insurgents can frame themselves as avengers or alternative authorities. These grievances often concentrate in exactly the places where governance is most “thin”, rural peripheries, so they compound over time rather than dissipate.

Inter-communal tensions also play a major role, particularly where livelihoods are fragile and competition over land, water, or trade routes is intense. Extremist groups often exploit these fractures, aligning with one side temporarily or inflaming distrust to prevent unified resistance. Border porosity and arms flows amplify everything: small arms and light weapons circulate through trafficking networks that are difficult to disrupt without coordinated regional enforcement and anti-corruption measures. Where weapons are plentiful and governance is weak, violence becomes easier to start and harder to stop, and criminal economies can merge with extremist financing. Delegates

should also watch the “blended threat” problem: kidnapping-for-profit, banditry, and extremist violence can intersect, creating partnerships of convenience even when ideologies differ.

The policy challenge is that counterterrorism measures can accidentally worsen these drivers if they rely on collective suspicion rather than targeted accountability. Overbroad crackdowns, discriminatory profiling, mass detentions without transparent processes, and heavy restrictions on movement can punish entire communities and create exactly the alienation extremists need. This is where the distinction between preventing violent extremism and counterterrorism becomes operationally meaningful: prevention focuses on reducing recruitment conditions and rebuilding trust, while counterterrorism focuses on disrupting immediate threats. Delegates should be encouraged to design strategies that do both, because a purely kinetic approach may win battles but lose legitimacy, and legitimacy is the long-term terrain of this conflict. The strongest committee proposals will therefore integrate (1) calibrated security operations with civilian harm mitigation and oversight, (2) governance and justice reforms that make the state feel present in services, not only in force, and (3) regional coordination that reduces cross-border sanctuary while keeping humanitarian access protected through clear carve-outs and monitoring.

Humanitarian Impact and its Assessment

The humanitarian consequences of extremist violence in Nigeria are measurable, compounding, and politically destabilizing. Displacement is one of the clearest indicators: communities flee attacks, retaliation cycles, or fear of forced recruitment, often leaving behind farms, livestock, and social networks. This displacement then accelerates food insecurity, as agricultural production drops and supply lines become dangerous or controlled. When markets cannot function, prices rise, malnutrition spreads, and households adopt survival strategies that increase long-term harm, pulling children out of school, reducing meals, or marrying off daughters early to reduce perceived burdens or secure protection. This “survival economy” is not only a welfare crisis; it becomes a security problem because it deepens grievance, erodes community resilience, and widens the pool of people vulnerable to coercion, trafficking, or recruitment.

Gender-based violence risk rises sharply in conflict settings, particularly in displacement contexts where women and girls face threats during flight, in camps, and in host communities under economic strain. These risks often increase when basic protections fail, poor lighting, overcrowded shelters, weak reporting mechanisms, or reliance on unsafe routes for water and firewood collection. Child recruitment and exploitation are not only violations in themselves but also drivers of conflict persistence: children forced into armed groups may become both victims and perpetrators, and communities may later resist reintegration efforts due to fear and trauma. Schooling collapse matters here as more than a social tragedy, it is a strategic loss. Closed schools create idle youth, weaken community cohesion, and remove one of the strongest protective factors against recruitment. From an international protection lens, this intersects directly with obligations under the Convention on the

Rights of the Child and the Optional Protocol on children in armed conflict, reinforcing that child protection is not “optional programming” but a core conflict-response requirement.

Access constraints shape every humanitarian metric. When aid convoys cannot move safely, when authorities restrict movement, or when armed groups tax or threaten humanitarian operations, the principle of impartial life-saving assistance becomes difficult to uphold. The legal and ethical lens is built around human rights protections and humanitarian principles such as neutrality, impartiality, independence, and “do no harm,” as operationalized through UN humanitarian coordination norms (including the framework associated with UNGA Resolution 46/182). For delegates, the practical question is how to design security and screening measures that prevent infiltration without turning IDP sites into punitive or carceral environments that further victimize civilians. This is where humanitarian policy and security policy become inseparable: how you treat civilians during crisis operations will determine whether communities view the state as a protector or an occupying force. It also shapes intelligence and cooperation, abusive screening or arbitrary detention can produce silence and fear, while fair procedures can build trust and improve early warning.

Nigeria’s extremist violence cannot be contained within national borders, and the Lake Chad Basin is the clearest proof. Armed groups exploit borderlands not only as escape routes but as strategic depth, moving fighters, abductees, and resources across frontiers to complicate pursuit and prosecution. Border operations and joint task arrangements exist precisely because no single state can patrol every crossing or disrupt every network alone. Yet coordination is difficult: states have different threat perceptions, different capabilities, and different political incentives. The result can be uneven pressure, strong operations in one area pushing fighters into another, or inconsistent rules of engagement creating “safe” corridors for armed groups. In committee, delegates should treat this as a classic regional security dilemma: cooperation is necessary, but mistrust and uneven burden-sharing make it fragile.

Refugee flows and cross-border displacement add a second layer. As people flee violence, neighboring countries face humanitarian strain, local tensions, and security concerns about infiltration. Protection duties are shaped by international refugee law (including the 1951 Refugee Convention and the 1967 Protocol) and by regional standards that often broaden protection concepts in practice. Donor financing becomes a major factor here, influencing which programs survive, which security initiatives scale up, and how much leverage international partners hold. However, donor priorities can shift, and short-term funding cycles often fail to match the long-term nature of rebuilding governance, restoring livelihoods, and supporting trauma recovery. This mismatch encourages “project logic” (quick outputs) rather than “systems logic” (durable institutions), which is one reason humanitarian gains can evaporate once media attention and funding decline.

Legally and politically, cross-border operations raise recurring debates about consent, notification, and proportionality. Even when states share a common enemy, sovereignty concerns and domestic politics can make cooperation fragile, and accusations of unlawful entry or civilian harm can quickly

derail coordination. Delegates should understand that regional coordination is not simply “more meetings” or “more troops,” but a contested negotiation over authority, accountability, intelligence sharing, and the acceptable costs of escalation. Done well, regional coordination can close gaps extremists exploit; done poorly, it can create rivalry, duplication, and civilian harm that undermines legitimacy across the entire basin. The committee should encourage delegates to specify mechanisms, joint verification, shared deconfliction channels, transparent incident reporting, and civilian harm mitigation standards, rather than relying on vague calls for “enhanced cooperation.”

Nigeria and its partners have pursued a mix of military offensives, stabilization programs, deradicalization initiatives, and humanitarian responses, yet persistent gaps remain, especially in DDR (disarmament, demobilization, reintegration) and community trust. Deradicalization and rehabilitation programs face credibility challenges: communities may fear returning ex-combatants, victims may feel justice is neglected, and authorities may prioritize rapid demobilization numbers over long-term reintegration success. Reintegration is not just an administrative process; it is a social bargain. Without livelihood pathways, psychosocial support, and community reconciliation, former fighters may return to armed groups, and communities may respond with vigilante violence, restarting cycles of instability. This is also where transitional justice debates enter: whether accountability is pursued through prosecutions, truth-telling mechanisms, reparations, or hybrid arrangements, and how those choices affect both deterrence and the willingness of fighters to demobilize.

These difficulties are even sharper when former fighters are minors. Children associated with armed groups require rights-based rehabilitation that treats them primarily as victims of unlawful recruitment and exploitation, while still addressing the real harm communities may have suffered. Programs that detain children for extended periods, stigmatize them, or fail to provide education and family reunification can create a new generation of trauma and resentment. The most common failure pattern in past efforts is a mismatch between short-term security metrics and long-term resilience needs: operations clear areas without holding them, rehabilitation releases individuals without reintegrating them, and aid meets immediate needs without restoring the governance and livelihoods that prevent relapse. In the Nigerian context, delegates should be pushed to think in “sequencing”: clear-and-hold that includes local civilian protection, stabilization that restores basic services quickly, and reintegration that is paced to community absorption capacity, because compressing these stages for headline results tends to recreate the conditions for the next wave of violence.

Key Points of Contention and Key Takeaways

In committee, delegate conflict lines will likely center on the tradeoff between security-first and rights-first approaches, though in reality, the most effective strategies must integrate both. Some delegates will push for intensified military escalation, arguing that extremist groups must be decisively weakened before any political or developmental progress is possible. Others will warn that

escalation without safeguards increases civilian harm, drives displacement, and strengthens extremist narratives, ultimately prolonging the conflict. This debate often becomes polarized, but the most productive crisis outcomes tend to come from forcing concrete design choices: what oversight mechanisms exist, what accountability triggers apply, and how civilian harm is tracked and addressed. Delegates can ground this clash in international frameworks that explicitly link counterterrorism to rule-of-law compliance, particularly the UN Global Counter-Terrorism Strategy (A/RES/60/288) and the post-9/11 Security Council architecture (e.g., Resolution 1373 (2001)), which created broad obligations to suppress terrorist financing and support prosecutions while also insisting measures conform with international law. The committee should therefore treat “rights” not as a moral add-on but as an operational variable: legitimacy, intelligence flow, community cooperation, and long-term recruitment conditions depend on whether communities experience the state as protective and lawful.

A second contention will pit military-heavy responses against community stabilization approaches. Stabilization is slower, harder to measure, and politically less dramatic than battlefield wins, but it is often the difference between temporary calm and lasting security, especially in “clear, hold, build” environments where security gains evaporate if governance and services do not follow. Delegates will also likely clash over screening and security measures in IDP camps. Authorities may argue screening is necessary to prevent infiltration and protect residents, especially where fighters blend into civilian flows and where armed groups have historically exploited displacement corridors. Humanitarian actors and rights-focused delegates may argue that aggressive screening, mass detention, or movement restrictions can turn camps into abusive environments that violate protections and fuel fear, implicating fair-trial norms (ICCPR) and displacement protection commitments (including the Kampala Convention). These disputes matter because camps are not just humanitarian sites, they are political symbols of state capacity and legitimacy. If camps resemble containment zones rather than protected civilian spaces, they become propaganda assets for insurgents and flashpoints for local grievance, undermining both humanitarian goals and security objectives.

The rise and evolution of ISIS-affiliated groups can be woven into the discussion as an example of how factional splits, rebranding, and transnational affiliation can shift tactics and recruitment narratives without changing the underlying drivers. In Nigeria’s context, this is not simply “branding”; affiliation can change funding streams, target selection, media strategy, and claims to religious or political authority, which in turn affects who gets recruited and how violence is justified. The impact on regional security fits naturally into the Lake Chad Basin analysis, showing why borders are operational opportunities for extremists and strategic vulnerabilities for states: fighters and resources can move through lightly governed borderlands, while joint enforcement becomes politically sensitive and uneven in practice. This is where regional security cooperation frameworks and joint operations become contested in committee, not only as security tools, but as questions of mandate, consent, intelligence sharing, and accountability when operations cross into border areas or involve multiple national forces. Civilian protection and state response should serve as the unifying thread across all sections: how force is used, how civilians are treated, and how trust is rebuilt are

not side issues, they are the battlefield on which extremist violence either persists or collapses. In crisis terms, the strongest directives will be those that connect these strands into a single logic: calibrated force with enforceable safeguards, stabilization that restores services and justice quickly enough to “hold” territory politically, and regional coordination that closes sanctuary routes without creating new legitimacy crises through civilian harm or perceived sovereignty violations.

C. Crisis in the Democratic Republic of the Congo

Background and Current Situation

The crisis in the Democratic Republic of the Congo (DRC) is best understood as three conflicts layered on top of one another: a domestic struggle over authority and protection, a regional contest shaped by borders and security fears, and an economic war over access to wealth, especially where the state is weakest and armed actors are strongest. The violence is “internal” because it is rooted in local governance gaps, community tensions, and the inability of the Congolese state to provide consistent security and services across its enormous territory. At the same time, the conflict is “regional” because armed groups, refugees, and military pressures move across borders, and neighboring states are perceived, rightly or wrongly, as shaping outcomes through influence, support, or strategic toleration. Finally, it is “economic” because the conflict’s persistence is not only ideological or political; it is financed and incentivized through systems of taxation, smuggling, extortion, and resource extraction that make insecurity profitable. This three-layer reality is why the DRC repeatedly resists “single-cause” explanations: progress in one layer (a ceasefire, a new political coalition, a localized security gain) can be undone if the other two layers remain intact.

A defining feature of the current landscape is armed group proliferation. Eastern DRC in particular has become a dense mosaic of armed factions with overlapping motives: some claim political or ethnic protection goals, others function as criminal networks, and many blend both. Where the state’s presence is thin, armed groups fill the vacuum by controlling roads, markets, and mines, setting up parallel systems of governance that extract revenue and impose coercive order. Governance challenges compound this: security forces may be under-resourced, fragmented, or distrusted; local administration may be absent or corrupt; and political competition can fuel violence when armed actors are used as proxies or when communities feel excluded. The result is a cycle in which insecurity prevents state-building, and weak state-building allows insecurity to regenerate. International stabilization has long tried to manage this cycle through the UN peacekeeping architecture, first MONUC, established by Security Council Resolution 1279 (1999), and later MONUSCO, created by Resolution 1925 (2010), but those missions have faced the same structural constraint: they can reduce harm at the margins, yet they cannot substitute for a legitimate and capable state across the east.

Community-level violence is both a driver and a consequence. In many areas, disputes over land, customary authority, or identity-based grievances escalate when weapons are available and when

outside armed groups exploit local fears. Attacks are often not random but strategically targeted to displace populations, seize territory, punish rivals, or control economic corridors. Displacement, therefore, is not just a humanitarian statistic, it is a mechanism of war. Families flee repeatedly as frontlines shift, and displacement camps and host communities become pressure points where disease, exploitation, and resentment increase. Key flashpoints typically emerge where strategic value concentrates: mineral-rich zones, border-adjacent territories, major transport routes, and politically symbolic towns where control signals dominance. This is also why ceasefires that focus only on “frontline stabilization” often fail: unless local land disputes, community protection fears, and predatory revenue systems are addressed, violence reappears through new actors even when one group temporarily stands down.

The legal dispute at the core of this agenda revolves around territorial integrity and the question of external support to armed groups. Even when violence manifests through local militias and internal fragmentation, the allegation that outside actors enable armed groups, through training, arms flows, financing, or sanctuary, transforms the conflict from a purely domestic problem into an international legal and diplomatic crisis. That tension shapes nearly every policy debate in committee: if the conflict is treated as internal, the emphasis falls on governance reform and reconciliation; if treated as externally fueled, the emphasis shifts to sovereignty, border security, and international pressure. Recent diplomatic battles around armed group offensives in the Kivus illustrate how quickly this becomes Security Council business, often framed explicitly as demands to end support to specific armed groups and respect Congolese sovereignty.

The DRC conflict arena includes state institutions that carry formal authority, armed groups that hold de facto power on the ground, neighboring states whose policies shape cross-border realities, and international actors, especially UN-linked mechanisms, attempting to stabilize conditions while navigating sovereignty constraints. On the Congolese state side, national leadership and security institutions remain central, but their effectiveness varies dramatically by region. The army and police are often expected to fight insurgents, protect civilians, and secure borders simultaneously, even where logistics and command cohesion are limited. Local and provincial authorities also matter because many disputes originate at the community level: land access, customary leadership, resource licensing, and local political competition can all become triggers that armed actors exploit. Meanwhile, international and regional frameworks, like the Peace, Security and Cooperation Framework for the DRC and the region (signed in Addis Ababa on 24 February 2013), seek to bind both domestic reforms and regional non-interference into a single bargain, precisely because “internal” and “regional” dynamics cannot be cleanly separated in practice.

Armed groups are not a single category but a spectrum. Some are highly organized and territorially ambitious; others are localized militias formed around community defense narratives; and some operate primarily as profit-seeking networks. This matters for delegates because different groups respond to different incentives. A faction seeking political concessions might engage in talks if offered guarantees, while a group sustained by smuggling revenues may have no reason to stop fighting unless the financial system behind it is disrupted. In many cases, armed groups also survive

through relationships, coercive or cooperative, with civilians: forced taxation, recruitment, control of agriculture, and regulation of trade. Any crisis plan that imagines armed groups as external “invaders” rather than embedded actors will fail to address how they actually endure. Even where armed factions claim to defend communities, the coercive economy they build, checkpoints, “protection” fees, forced labor, and intimidation, often becomes indistinguishable from organized predation.

Neighboring states occupy a uniquely sensitive role. They may claim legitimate security concerns, such as cross-border armed threats, refugee pressures, or destabilization spillovers, while also being accused of interference, opportunism, or indirect proxy engagement. Whether these accusations are accepted or contested in committee, the perception alone shapes escalation risks and diplomatic gridlock. Meanwhile, the UN mission (and associated UN mechanisms) sits in the middle: expected to protect civilians, support stabilization, and deter armed groups, yet constrained by host-state consent, political pressures, limited resources, and the challenge of operating in a fragmented conflict environment. This creates an enduring credibility trap: when the UN acts forcefully, it risks being seen as infringing sovereignty; when it acts cautiously, it risks being seen as ineffective, especially as debates over MONUSCO drawdown and transition intensify whenever violence spikes.

The legal lens here is state responsibility, especially regarding support, safe havens, and cross-border effects. Delegates should understand that “responsibility” debates are not abstract, they influence whether the committee leans toward sanctions, investigations, border monitoring, diplomatic pressure, or security guarantees. The DRC sanctions architecture itself is a standing example of how the UN treats the conflict as a matter of international peace and security: Resolution 1533 (2004) created the DRC Sanctions Committee and associated expert monitoring, building an enforcement model around arms flows and armed group networks rather than treating violence as purely domestic disorder. Even the suspicion of external enablement can harden positions, making internal reforms harder to implement and international coordination more politically costly.

“Resources” are often invoked as shorthand for the DRC conflict, but the more precise reality is that resources become conflict drivers through specific incentive structures: who controls extraction sites, who controls transport routes, and who controls the systems that convert minerals into money. Mines and mineral zones matter not only because of their value, but because they require labor, security, and logistics, creating opportunities for armed actors to tax, coerce, and regulate. Control of roads can be as profitable as control of mines because roads determine who can move goods to markets. Smuggling routes, especially those connected to borders, allow armed groups and corrupt intermediaries to bypass state oversight and convert raw materials into cash or weapons. This is the core political economy problem: as long as violence reliably produces revenue, armed actors have rational incentives to keep insecurity “managed” rather than resolved.

Taxation and extortion are central. Armed groups often set up checkpoints, impose “protection” fees on traders, demand payments from miners, and extract from civilians through forced labor or confiscation. This turns insecurity into a business model: violence is not simply a means to political

ends, it is a method of maintaining revenue streams. Corruption can further entangle the conflict economy, as officials, brokers, and armed actors sometimes participate in overlapping networks that make enforcement selectively applied and trust difficult to rebuild. Delegates should treat this as a governance-and-markets problem as much as a battlefield problem: unless the committee proposes ways to reduce the profitability of coercion (and increase the profitability of lawful livelihoods), armed groups will adapt around whatever security pressure is applied.

Social drivers intersect with these economic incentives. Communities with unresolved land disputes, historical grievances, or identity-based fears can be mobilized into armed factions, especially when they believe the state cannot protect them or is aligned against them. Once mobilized, violence can take on a life of its own: retaliatory cycles, fear-based displacement, and the normalization of armed authority make demobilization harder. Governance weakness, limited service delivery, lack of dispute resolution mechanisms, and impunity, provides the permissive environment in which these drivers flourish. This is why “security sector reform” is never only technical: if communities do not trust policing, courts, and local administration, then armed self-help remains rational, even when it is devastating.

The legal/policy lens on this driver set includes the framing of pillage and illegal resource exploitation as potential international crimes and the use of sanctions that target supply chains rather than only battlefield actors. This is strategically significant: if the committee treats resources as a downstream symptom rather than a core incentive, it will prioritize ceasefires and troop deployments while leaving the financial engine intact. Conversely, supply-chain-focused strategies, monitoring, tracing, targeted sanctions, and anti-corruption measures, aim to make conflict less profitable, though they also risk harming livelihoods if implemented without protection measures for civilians and legitimate local miners. The strongest committee outcomes will therefore link “follow-the-money” tools to civilian protections and local economic alternatives, so that disrupting conflict finance does not become indistinguishable from punishing survival economies in already-fragile communities.

Humanitarian Impact of the Conflict

The humanitarian impact in the DRC is defined not only by the scale of suffering but by the complexity of protection dilemmas. Civilians face violence from multiple directions: armed groups that attack for control, retaliate against perceived collaboration, or forcibly recruit; criminal actors that exploit insecurity; and sometimes state-linked forces whose operations can produce abuse or displacement if accountability is weak. Many attacks are designed to terrorize communities into flight, which then allows armed actors to seize land, mines, or strategic routes with minimal resistance. Sexual and gender-based violence is frequently used as a weapon of intimidation and social destruction, compounding trauma and fracturing community cohesion. This is why “civilian protection” in the DRC is not a single task (deploy troops, patrol roads) but a continuous contest

over whether communities can live, move, farm, and access markets without needing armed patronage.

Displacement patterns are often cyclical rather than linear. Families may flee, return, flee again, and fragment across multiple locations depending on shifting threats. Camps and informal settlements can provide temporary refuge but also expose people to new dangers: exploitation, disease outbreaks, restricted movement, and dependence on aid. Humanitarian access becomes an operational challenge when armed groups control roads, demand “taxes,” or threaten aid workers; at the same time, the presence of aid can become politicized, with communities accusing agencies of favoritism or authorities viewing them as undermining state legitimacy. In practice, aid delivery can become part of the conflict economy: whoever controls checkpoints can extract revenue, and whoever controls “permission” can shape which communities receive support, turning life-saving assistance into another lever of coercion.

From the legal/policy lens, civilian protection obligations are central, as is the prevention of mass atrocity risks in areas where violence escalates rapidly and accountability is weak. Delegates should understand that protection is not simply about deploying forces; it involves early warning, community engagement, safe corridors, accountability mechanisms, and real consequences for perpetrators. The accountability dimension matters because impunity is a long-term driver: when civilians believe violence carries no cost, trust collapses, retaliation becomes rational, and armed groups can recruit by promising “justice” through violence. This is also where the UN system’s credibility is tested: MONUSCO’s mandate and posture have been repeatedly debated precisely because civilians often judge international engagement by one question, “Did it reduce the risk to my family?”, and public frustration rises when expectations outpace capacity.

The regional dimension, especially the Rwanda-related controversy, must be presented in a way that avoids oversimplification. In many political narratives, the crisis is framed as either (a) a Congolese internal failure of governance and security or (b) a conflict primarily driven by external interference and proxy warfare. In practice, both dynamics can coexist, and focusing exclusively on one produces policy failure. Regional histories of cross-border armed movements, refugee flows, and longstanding security anxieties shape how neighboring governments interpret threats emanating from eastern DRC. At the same time, Congolese perceptions of sovereignty violations and resource predation shape domestic politics and harden resistance to negotiated security arrangements that appear to legitimize foreign influence. This is why even well-designed technical fixes (joint patrols, verification teams, demobilization plans) can fail politically if they are perceived as conceding sovereignty or “rewarding” alleged interference.

International actors add another layer: diplomatic initiatives, sanctions regimes, peacekeeping mandates, and humanitarian financing all shape the operating environment. However, these tools can pull in different directions. Sanctions may deter external support or armed group financing, but they can also become political symbols that inflame nationalism or reduce diplomatic flexibility. Peacekeeping and international stabilization efforts can protect civilians in specific areas, but they

cannot substitute for national governance, and they often become targets of public frustration when expectations outpace capacity. The sanctions architecture itself illustrates how international policy treats the conflict as more than a purely domestic emergency: the UN DRC Sanctions Committee was established pursuant to Security Council Resolution 1533 (2004) to oversee arms-embargo-related measures and monitoring, an explicit recognition that arms flows and external networks are central to the violence.

The legal/policy debate here is a direct clash between non-use of force and non-intervention principles versus claims of security spillover and self-defense logic. Delegates should recognize the strategic implication: if the committee accepts a spillover framing, it may prioritize joint border security, intelligence sharing, and regional security guarantees; if it accepts a non-intervention framing, it may prioritize condemnation, investigations, sanctions, and reinforcement of territorial integrity. The difficulty, and the opportunity for strong delegate strategy, is designing a pathway that reduces cross-border threats without normalizing interference or undermining Congolese sovereignty. One way to make this “committee-usable” is to force specificity: verification mechanisms, limits on cross-border operations, transparent reporting, and consequences for violations, because vague affirmations of sovereignty or security needs rarely change behavior on the ground.

Ceasefires and mediation efforts in the DRC context often fail not because diplomacy is meaningless, but because enforcement and incentives are weak in a fragmented battlefield economy. Agreements are frequently signed by political or military elites who do not fully control all armed actors, especially local militias with community-based agendas or profit-driven networks. Even when major factions commit on paper, splinter groups emerge, spoilers escalate violence to gain attention, and implementation stalls due to mistrust and competing interests. In addition, ceasefires that freeze positions without addressing revenue streams can effectively entrench armed groups by giving them time to consolidate control over mines, roads, and taxation systems. This is a core “political economy” trap: when insecurity is profitable, ceasefire periods can become consolidation periods unless monitoring and financial disruption are built in from the start.

Enforcement fails when monitoring mechanisms are underpowered, when consequences for violations are inconsistent, and when civilian protection is not prioritized during implementation. Demobilization and integration programs can also produce perverse incentives: armed actors may maintain violence to secure bargaining power or access to reintegration benefits, while communities may resist reintegration if justice and reparations are ignored. Political timelines and security reforms often move slowly, and the mismatch between diplomatic pacing and battlefield realities creates repeated collapses. This is why regional frameworks have repeatedly tried to link domestic reform commitments and regional non-interference into a single bargain, most notably the Peace, Security and Cooperation Framework for the DRC and the region (signed in Addis Ababa on 24 February 2013), which explicitly recognized that the crisis cannot be solved by internal reforms or regional commitments alone.

Peacekeeping mandates illustrate the core tension: missions are expected to be robust enough to protect civilians and deter armed groups, but they are also constrained by consent, impartiality requirements, and political sensitivity. Robust protection can be interpreted as taking sides if the host government is itself contested or accused of abuses; insufficient action can be interpreted as failure or complicity when civilians suffer. Delegates should use this section to understand that the limits of peacekeeping are not just logistical, they are legal, political, and perceptual, and those limits shape what any new initiative can realistically accomplish. Historically, these constraints are embedded in the evolution of the UN presence itself, from MONUC's establishment under Resolution 1279 (1999) to MONUSCO's mandate under Resolution 1925 (2010), which reflects shifting expectations about civilian protection, stabilization, and what "success" even means in an environment where armed groups, borders, and resource incentives continually adapt.

Key Points of Contention and Take aways

In committee, disputes will likely cluster around three fault lines. First, sanctions versus diplomacy: some delegates will argue that pressure on armed group backers and conflict-economy networks is the only language that changes behavior; others will argue that sanctions harden positions, reduce room for negotiation, and can harm civilians through economic disruption. This debate becomes sharper once delegates distinguish what is being sanctioned: targeted measures aimed at armed group leadership, arms brokers, and conflict-finance facilitators are often framed as "precision tools," while broad restrictions can be framed as collective punishment. The UN's long-running DRC sanctions architecture is the reference point here: the Security Council established the sanctions committee through Resolution 1533 (2004) to oversee an arms embargo first imposed under Resolution 1493 (2003), alongside expert monitoring of arms flows and networks. Over time, the regime has been repeatedly adjusted, including narrowing the embargo's focus to non-governmental armed groups (e.g., Resolution 1807 (2008)) and later reducing notification requirements for government shipments (e.g., Resolution 2667 (2022)), which gives delegates real policy space to argue for tightening, recalibrating, or refocusing rather than treating "sanctions" as a single all-or-nothing lever.

Second, the scope of UN mission involvement versus sovereignty claims: one bloc may push for stronger protection mandates and more assertive operations, while another insists that external forces must not substitute for Congolese authority or infringe on political independence. Delegates can anchor this in the evolution of the UN mission itself: MONUSCO was established by Security Council Resolution 1925 (2010) to reflect a "new phase" of stabilization, with civilian protection remaining central, but always constrained by host-state consent and political legitimacy pressures. In practice, this fault line is also about expectations: communities may demand robust action against armed groups, while government officials may resist anything that looks like international tutelage. The committee should therefore push delegates to specify how stronger involvement would be made legitimate (joint planning, transparent reporting, civilian harm tracking, accountability triggers),

and how sovereignty concerns would be protected (defined operating boundaries, Congolese leadership roles, and clear exit/transition conditions).

Third, armed group integration versus justice demands: pragmatic delegates may favor integrating fighters and commanders to stop violence quickly, while others will argue that integrating perpetrators entrenches impunity and guarantees future cycles of abuse. This becomes a concrete design conflict when delegates debate sequencing: do you demobilize first and pursue accountability later (risking impunity), or insist on accountability up front (risking spoilers and continued fighting)? The hard truth the committee should surface is that “integration” is not automatically peacebuilding, without vetting, community consultation, victim-centered reparations, and credible oversight, integration can simply recycle coercive actors into state-linked structures and deepen civilian mistrust.

By the end of this section, delegates should clearly grasp three intertwined realities: the internal fragmentation of armed actors makes simple “peace deals” structurally fragile; regional tensions, particularly those involving Rwanda-related allegations and security narratives, turn local violence into international confrontation; and the resource-conflict entanglement finances and incentivizes prolonged insecurity. The committee’s challenge is therefore not just stopping fighting, but disrupting the systems that make fighting profitable while building a political settlement that does not sacrifice civilian protection or long-term legitimacy. This is why many initiatives pair political commitments with regional security guarantees and reform agendas: the 2013 Peace, Security and Cooperation Framework (Addis Ababa) was explicitly built to link Congolese reforms with regional non-interference and international support, recognizing that domestic fixes and regional commitments fail when pursued in isolation.

Armed Groups and Internal Fragmentation can be threaded throughout to show how splintering, localized agendas, and profit motives complicate negotiation and enforcement. Even when a named faction signs, commanders with local revenue streams may defect, spoilers may escalate violence to gain relevance, and “micro-conflicts” (land disputes, customary authority fights, local protection rackets) keep burning underneath national-level talks. This is also why enforcement mechanisms matter as much as signatures: monitoring that cannot verify violations, and consequences that are inconsistently applied, create a predictable pattern of ceasefire collapse and armed consolidation.

Regional Tensions and Rwanda’s Role should appear as a layered discussion of security narratives, sovereignty claims, and political perceptions rather than a single-cause explanation. The most useful committee framing is to treat the regional dimension as a bargaining problem: neighboring states may argue cross-border threats and spillover risks justify urgent security measures, while the DRC and its supporters emphasize territorial integrity and non-intervention. Contemporary mediation tracks illustrate this tension. The EAC-led Nairobi Process is formally designed to facilitate a negotiated resolution to eastern DRC instability through diplomatic engagement among regional stakeholders, but its effectiveness is constantly tested by trust deficits and competing end-states.

Meanwhile, shifts between mediation formats (and periodic breakdowns) show why regional diplomacy can become its own contested arena rather than a neutral solution.

Resource Conflict and Human Rights Violations should be used to connect economic incentives to civilian harm, showing how exploitation, displacement, and abuse are not side effects but often the mechanisms through which control is achieved and maintained. Resource control is exercised through coercive governance: checkpoints, “taxation,” forced labor, and intimidation that turn everyday movement and trade into revenue. That coercion produces humanitarian outcomes, flight, hunger, gender-based violence, and community fragmentation, because fear is how territory and extraction zones are “cleared.” For delegates, the takeaway is strategic: if plans treat resources as background context, armed actors keep their financial engine; if plans target conflict finance (supply-chain tracing, anti-smuggling enforcement, targeted sanctions, anti-corruption measures), delegates must also protect civilian livelihoods so disruption does not collapse survival economies. The strongest crisis strategies will therefore integrate all three threads at once: de-fragment armed actor incentives, reduce regional escalation pressures without normalizing interference, and make coercive extraction less profitable, while keeping civilian protection as the metric that determines legitimacy.

D. The Sudan Crisis

Background and Current Situation

The Sudan crisis is fundamentally a struggle over who controls the state, who controls the guns, and who gets to claim legitimacy on behalf of the country. While the fighting is often described in terms of two competing armed forces, the deeper story is institutional: Sudan’s political transition never resolved the core question of security sector control, and competing centers of coercive power eventually collided. In many states, civilian politics can survive political competition because the armed forces remain unified and subordinate to a single chain of command. In Sudan, the opposite dynamic hardened over time, armed institutions developed their own economic interests, their own patronage networks, and their own political ambitions. When transitional arrangements attempted to redefine authority, it raised an existential threat to actors who benefited from parallel power structures, turning negotiation into a zero-sum contest. This institutional breakdown is not new; it echoes earlier cycles where militarized governance outlasted civilian pacts, with security actors accumulating independent revenue streams and political leverage until the transition’s “civilian ceiling” became intolerable.

This is why the conflict is not just “fighting” but a battle over the meaning of governance itself: who has the authority to sign agreements, appoint officials, control borders, collect revenue, and represent Sudan abroad. State institutions, from ministries to local administrations, have been pulled into the conflict through forced alignment, collapse, or paralysis, leaving a vacuum where armed actors can dominate daily life. As the conflict expands across urban centers and rural regions alike, it

has also eroded the social and political legitimacy of formal governance. Civilians face a cruel reality: the entities claiming to govern may not be able, or willing, to provide security, services, or accountability, and in many areas the “state” is experienced as armed checkpoints rather than functioning institutions. In IR terms, Sudan is drifting from a crisis of government to a crisis of authority: coercion is present, but rule-based administration, predictable law enforcement, and public goods delivery are absent, creating space for localized power brokers and armed “micro-orders” to replace national governance.

The legal and policy questions start here, because recognition and diplomatic representation are not neutral technicalities; they shape the conflict’s incentives. Who is treated as the official authority affects access to financial systems, international forums, and aid coordination. It also affects whether agreements signed under pressure are treated as legally valid or politically binding. Delegates should treat recognition as a tool with consequences: legitimizing an authority can stabilize negotiations but also reward coercion; refusing recognition can uphold norms but also shrink diplomatic channels needed to stop violence. These stakes are intensified by how multilateral systems work in practice, representation can influence control over state assets abroad, participation in UN processes, and the credibility of claims to request assistance or block investigations. In other words, legitimacy is not only symbolic; it is a resource that can translate into money, mobility, and diplomatic shielding.

Any serious mapping of Sudan’s crisis must extend beyond the primary belligerents to include the ecosystem of actors who can amplify, constrain, or reshape the conflict. The main armed factions are the obvious drivers of battlefield outcomes, but they do not operate in a political vacuum. Civilian coalitions, professional associations, neighborhood resistance structures, and local community leaders shape legitimacy, mobilization, and the possibility of governance in areas not fully controlled by armed actors. In many contexts, these civilian actors are not simply “stakeholders”; they are the only remaining credible connectors between society and any future political settlement, because they often hold the trust that armed elites lack. This matters for any transition design: if civilian legitimacy is bypassed, negotiated outcomes risk becoming elite bargains that cannot be implemented, monitored, or defended socially once violence shifts location.

Regional mediators and neighboring states are similarly central because Sudan sits at a strategic crossroads. States in the region may have genuine concerns about spillover, refugees, and border insecurity, but they may also hold competing preferences about who should prevail or what kind of Sudan is “acceptable.” This produces overlapping mediation initiatives and rival diplomatic pressures, sometimes creating multiple negotiating tables that compete for legitimacy rather than reinforcing each other. International humanitarian actors, UN-linked agencies, and NGOs also become key players because access, logistics, and protection depend on them. They are often forced into constant negotiation not just with official authorities but with local commanders, community gatekeepers, and armed actors who treat aid as leverage. This is also where institutional mandates matter: the UN’s integrated transition mission framework (UNITAMS) was created to support Sudan’s transition, but conflict conditions can rapidly transform “transition support” into triage diplomacy and humanitarian coordination under severe constraints.

The accountability lens matters because the conduct of armed actors today shapes whether peace is possible tomorrow. Command responsibility is not merely a legal doctrine; it becomes a political fault line when leaders fear that ceasefires, disarmament, or power-sharing could expose them to future prosecution. This fear can make actors resist documentation, monitoring, and independent investigations. Delegates should therefore recognize that accountability risks can both deter abuses and harden resistance to compromise, depending on how sequencing and incentives are designed. Sudan's contemporary accountability landscape cannot be separated from earlier international action: the Security Council's referral of the Darfur situation to the ICC established a precedent that mass-atrocity pathways can remain legally "alive" for years, shaping elite risk calculations in later crises.

Ceasefires in Sudan often break because the drivers of fighting are structural, not accidental. One driver is incentives: when armed actors believe battlefield gains improve their negotiating position, "talks" become a cover for repositioning rather than a pathway to de-escalation. A second driver is fragmentation. Even if top leaders agree to a pause, local commanders may ignore it, splinter groups may escalate to prove relevance, and allied militias may pursue their own interests. This makes enforcement difficult and creates a credibility problem: civilians stop believing in ceasefires because violations feel inevitable, and international actors struggle to determine whether violations reflect policy or indiscipline. The practical implication for committee debate is blunt: ceasefire design must assume partial compliance and build around it, verification, reporting channels, and consequences cannot be optional "add-ons."

A third driver is the war economy. Conflict is sustained when violence becomes profitable, through control of trade routes, taxation at checkpoints, looting, capture of strategic infrastructure, and exploitation of commodities and border commerce. Once armed groups and networks become financially dependent on insecurity, peace becomes a threat to livelihoods of power-holders. This is why the crisis cannot be solved through military pressure alone or through elite negotiations alone; it requires disrupting the economic and logistical systems that reward continued fighting, while simultaneously offering off-ramps that do not simply recycle violence into new forms of patronage. In IR terms, the war economy creates "spoilers with salaries": actors whose rational interest is continued instability unless alternative revenue, security guarantees, or political access is credibly provided.

The arms flow debate sits at the center of feasibility. Even strong diplomatic agreements can collapse if weapons and financing continue to enter the system unchecked. Yet embargo discussions quickly become political: some actors argue embargoes are necessary to reduce harm and pressure belligerents; others argue they are unenforceable, selectively applied, or risk tilting the balance in favor of one side. In committee, delegates should be pushed to grapple with the real enforcement question: who monitors, through what mechanisms, with what consequences, and how do you prevent an embargo from becoming symbolic rather than effective? Sudan-specific precedent matters here: the Council's Darfur arms embargo and sanctions architecture, beginning with an embargo focus on non-governmental entities and later expanded to belligerents, illustrates both the

utility and limitations of sanctions regimes when borders are porous and enforcement is politically contested.

Past ceasefires and agreements in Sudan have often failed for reasons that repeat with depressing consistency: weak verification, limited buy-in beyond top leadership, and lack of credible enforcement. Agreements may announce humanitarian pauses or security arrangements without establishing who monitors compliance, how violations are documented, and what consequences follow. Without verification, each side claims the other violated first, and ceasefires collapse into mutual blame. Without buy-in, local commanders and affiliated militias treat agreements as irrelevant to their immediate interests. Without enforcement, violations become cost-free, turning ceasefires into temporary tactical pauses rather than binding commitments. Even the more recent protection-of-civilians commitments made in external talks demonstrate this gap: aspirational language can clarify obligations, but without monitoring, access guarantees, and penalties for obstruction, it struggles to change behavior on the ground.

Another recurring failure point is the mismatch between elite agreement and ground reality. Deals may focus on high-level political transitions while ignoring local security dynamics, community protection needs, and the economic incentives that keep fighters mobilized. Even well-structured agreements can fail if they assume that “the state” can implement policies when state institutions are fractured or controlled by armed actors. Delegates should understand that a future agreement must be designed like a system, linking verification, incentives, protection, and implementation capacity, rather than like a press release. A system approach also forces hard tradeoffs onto the table: whether accountability is immediate or sequenced, whether security arrangements are centralized or locally phased, and how international guarantees (political, financial, or logistical) are conditioned on measurable compliance rather than rhetorical commitments.

Humanitarian Impacts at a Regional and International Sphere

The humanitarian catastrophe in Sudan is not a downstream consequence of political conflict, it is one of the conflict’s central battlefields. Access constraints, displacement, and famine risk must be treated as core strategic issues because they reshape political legitimacy, fuel recruitment, and determine whether communities can survive long enough to participate in any peace process. When markets collapse and supply routes are cut, hunger becomes both a tool and a consequence of war, and “who controls access” becomes a form of coercive governance in its own right. This is why recent diplomacy has repeatedly tried to anchor humanitarian obligations in explicit commitments: the Jeddah Declaration of Commitment to Protect the Civilians of Sudan (May 2023) frames protection of civilians, respect for humanitarian relief, and restraint around essential services as baseline expectations rather than optional concessions. Displacement, whether from urban fighting, ethnic targeting, or generalized insecurity, fractures social networks and overwhelms host communities, creating new tensions and vulnerabilities that can ignite further conflict, including competition over land, water, and local political authority in border districts.

Humanitarian operations face layered risks: attacks on convoys, bureaucratic obstruction, checkpoint extortion, and politicization of aid distribution. Armed actors may seek to control who receives assistance to reward supporters, punish rivals, or claim credit for relief. Meanwhile, humanitarian agencies must balance neutrality and impartiality with practical realities, negotiating access may require engagement with actors whose legitimacy is contested, and security guarantees may be unreliable. This creates a constant dilemma: refusing engagement can mean civilians starve; engaging can be framed as legitimizing coercive authority. The result is an operational environment where “permission” itself becomes a bargaining chip, and humanitarian space is compressed not only by violence but by administrative warfare, paperwork, permits, delays, and selective approvals that can be as decisive as gunfire.

The legal and policy lens emphasizes humanitarian access and protection principles, but delegates should translate these into operational choices. Safeguarding aid means designing delivery models that reduce diversion, ensuring credible monitoring, protecting aid workers, and coordinating deconfliction mechanisms that are not dependent on a single faction’s goodwill. It also requires understanding that protecting civilians is inseparable from protecting humanitarian space: when aid becomes a weaponized resource, humanitarian action can unintentionally become part of the conflict economy unless carefully structured. This is also where international commitments and Security Council messaging matter in practice: Council outcomes in 2024 explicitly called for humanitarian pauses and for parties to comply with international humanitarian law, including enabling relief and protecting civilians, yet the credibility of these demands hinges on whether violations trigger real costs or are met with diplomatic fatigue.

Sudan’s crisis has immediate spillover effects that pull surrounding states and distant powers into the conflict’s orbit. Refugee flows strain border regions and reshape domestic politics in neighboring countries. Arms trafficking and cross-border militia movements can destabilize already fragile areas. Trade disruptions and insecurity along key corridors can ripple through regional markets. These spillovers mean that even states claiming neutrality often face practical pressure to take a position, whether through border policy, mediation roles, or alignment with one peace track over another. In IR terms, Sudan is not only a civil war; it is a regional stress test that converts humanitarian movement into security dilemmas (screening, border militarization, and proxy accusations), while also internationalizing the conflict through diaspora politics, sanctions debates, and external financing narratives.

The mediation architecture is crowded, and that crowding is itself a problem. Multiple peace initiatives can be helpful when coordinated, different actors may have different leverage, access, or credibility. But when tracks compete, belligerents can forum-shop: they may engage where terms are favorable, stall where pressure is high, and exploit diplomatic fragmentation to avoid real commitments. Competing tracks also generate legitimacy disputes: which process is “the” process, whose proposals count, and which guarantees are credible. For delegates, the key is to treat coordination not as a bureaucratic nicety but as the difference between a coherent peace strategy and a patchwork of failed talks. The Security Council has increasingly framed civilian protection and

humanitarian access as non-negotiable pillars that should be reflected across mediation venues, precisely because fragmented diplomacy lets parties “agree” to principles in one room and violate them in another.

Legally and politically, competing peace tracks raise questions about who has authority to convene, who can claim representation, and whether agreements reached in one forum bind actors in another. Coordination failures can undermine enforcement because monitoring and verification require shared standards and shared consequences. In committee, delegates should be forced to confront a practical dilemma: if different mediators propose different ceasefire terms, different sequencing, and different accountability language, which version becomes the operational foundation, and how do you align incentives so that parties cannot exploit inconsistency? This is not abstract: even where the Council has made specific demands tied to concrete humanitarian stakes, such as calls linked to Darfur flashpoints, implementation still depends on unified external messaging, workable monitoring arrangements, and a credible escalation ladder if access is blocked or civilians are targeted.

Key Points of Contention and Major Takeaways

The committee should anticipate sharp disagreement over ceasefire verification models. Some delegates will advocate robust, internationally supported monitoring with clear reporting and consequences, arguing that without it ceasefires are fiction, especially given how quickly “pauses” collapse when violations are deniable and cost-free. They will point to the Security Council’s repeated emphasis on cessation of hostilities and time-bound humanitarian pauses (including calls tied to Ramadan) as evidence that the problem is not declaring ceasefires but operationalizing them through credible monitoring and compliance pathways. Others will argue that heavy external monitoring infringes sovereignty, is politically biased, or is impractical in active combat zones, particularly where frontlines shift rapidly, command chains are fragmented, and monitors can become targets or leverage. This dispute is rarely just technical; it is a proxy fight over who gets to define “violation,” who controls the narrative, and whether enforcement mechanisms are designed to constrain both parties equally or to isolate one actor as the primary spoiler.

A second contention will revolve around sanctions or embargo measures versus preserving negotiation space. Pressure tools may be framed as necessary leverage to stop atrocities and force compliance, with delegates citing existing UN frameworks like the Sudan (Darfur) sanctions regime created by Security Council resolution 1591 (2005) as proof that the Council has long accepted targeted measures (asset freezes, travel bans, and an arms embargo architecture) when civilian protection collapses. Opponents may argue sanctions harden positions, push actors toward illicit financing, or reduce incentives to negotiate, especially if measures are perceived as selective or unenforceable across porous borders. The practical IR question delegates should be forced to answer is enforcement credibility: if sanctions are proposed, who collects evidence, what triggers

designation, and how do you prevent the “war economy adaptation effect,” where armed networks simply reroute trade and funding rather than reduce violence?

A third and often decisive dispute concerns accountability versus “peace first” sequencing. Some delegates will insist that meaningful peace requires credible justice pathways, because impunity guarantees recurrence and signals to commanders that civilian abuse is a viable tactic. Others will argue that prioritizing accountability early makes leaders fight to the end out of fear, and that stabilization must precede justice. Here, the committee should push beyond slogans into design choices: do you sequence accountability (e.g., immediate documentation and independent fact-finding now, prosecutions later), or do you build conditionality into incentives (e.g., amnesties categorically excluded for atrocity crimes, but reintegration benefits tied to verified compliance)? This dilemma becomes sharper in Sudan because “legitimacy tools” and institutional architecture are already contested, especially after the Security Council terminated UNITAMS’ mandate in late 2023, reducing one channel for internationally anchored political accompaniment and leaving coordination gaps that parties can exploit. In practice, crisis committees thrive when they force delegates to operationalize their position: if you prioritize accountability, what incentives keep parties at the table and reduce spoiler violence? If you prioritize peace first, what safeguards prevent the agreement from becoming amnesty-by-another-name and locking in coercive governance? The most credible strategies will be those that connect humanitarian imperatives, security arrangements, and political legitimacy into one coherent sequence rather than treating them as separate debates.

Power Struggles and Armed Conflict should frame the crisis as a contest over state authority and security sector control, emphasizing why legitimacy and governance collapse are not side issues but the conflict’s core fuel. Delegates should treat “who governs” as a material question with institutional consequences, representation, access to financial systems, border control, and administrative reach, and recognize that competing claims to authority can prolong war by turning negotiations into a zero-sum struggle for recognition rather than a pathway to shared implementation capacity.

Humanitarian Catastrophe and Displacement should anchor the discussion in civilian realities, hunger, displacement, and access, showing how humanitarian collapse reshapes political outcomes and conflict incentives. The key takeaway is that humanitarian access is not merely relief; it is leverage, legitimacy, and survival. Security Council language on enabling sustained cross-border and cross-line humanitarian assistance (including specific attention to Darfur) highlights how access has become a central strategic variable in the conflict rather than a downstream concern.

Regional and International Implications should tie together spillover pressures, competing mediation tracks, and the strategic consequences of fragmented diplomacy, reinforcing that Sudan’s crisis is both a domestic tragedy and a regional destabilizer that demands coordinated, credible action. Delegates should treat “mediation crowding” as a conflict driver: when processes compete, belligerents can forum-shop, dilute commitments, and avoid enforcement. The committee’s central

takeaway should be that coordination is not procedural, it is the difference between a coherent pressure-and-incentives framework and a patchwork of parallel talks that rewards delay.

E. The Yemen Civil War

Introduction to the Issue

Yemen's war is often described as a civil conflict, but it is more accurately a layered crisis where internal fragmentation, regional power competition, and strategic maritime geography collide. What began as a struggle over political transition and state authority has evolved into a prolonged contest in which multiple armed and political actors claim legitimacy, control different territories, and rely on external patrons to sustain their positions. This creates a conflict environment where "ending the war" is not a single decision point but a complex process of aligning incentives across rival institutions, repairing basic governance, and restoring a minimum level of economic functionality. Yemen's tragedy, and the reason it fits so squarely under the idea of "silent war," is that the violence and its consequences have persisted for years with periodic spikes in global attention, even as the daily realities of hunger, displacement, and institutional collapse remain constant. Internationally, the conflict has also been legally "structured" by recurring UN Security Council action, most notably Resolution 2216 (2015), which anchored a sanctions and arms-control framework and continues to shape diplomatic positioning about legitimacy, pressure tools, and what counts as "compliance."

The "regionalized" character of Yemen's war matters because it changes both the balance of power and the costs of failure. External involvement has not merely added resources; it has reshaped war aims, negotiation dynamics, and escalation risks. At the same time, Yemen's location makes it impossible to treat the conflict as geographically isolated. The country sits near one of the world's most critical maritime corridors, linking the Red Sea to the Gulf of Aden and beyond. This means that Yemen is not only a land war with humanitarian consequences, it is also a conflict with maritime stakes, where control of ports, coastal territories, and sea access can influence trade security, regional deterrence postures, and international responses. Delegates should therefore approach Yemen as a crisis where land, sea, politics, and humanitarian access are tightly braided together: choices made in one area immediately shape outcomes in the others. That interdependence is visible in how humanitarian and commercial flows have been tied to maritime governance tools, such as the UN Verification and Inspection Mechanism (UNVIM), created to facilitate commercial cargo into Yemen's Red Sea ports while addressing concerns about illicit arms flows.

The current situation in Yemen reflects the collapse of a contested political transition into a multi-front conflict where state authority splintered faster than any peace process could consolidate. As institutions weakened, rival centers of power filled the vacuum, building parallel governance structures, security apparatuses, and revenue systems. Over time, frontlines hardened in some areas while remaining fluid in others, producing a patchwork of territorial control that makes the country

feel less like a single state and more like a landscape of competing administrations. In such an environment, the “state” becomes an argument rather than a reality: different actors claim to represent Yemen internationally, different authorities collect taxes and run services locally, and ordinary people navigate whichever power structure controls their immediate surroundings. This is why “who speaks for Yemen” is not just diplomatic theater; it affects banking access, aid coordination, and the perceived legality of agreements signed in one capital but implemented (or ignored) on the ground.

Yemen’s war must also be understood as a regionalized conflict because external backing has provided resources, training, political cover, and strategic direction to local partners, deepening both the war’s longevity and its geopolitical significance. Regional involvement has introduced broader strategic calculations, deterrence, influence, border security, and maritime posture, that can override or complicate purely Yemeni political solutions. This is why ceasefires and partial agreements sometimes stabilize one arena while tensions rise elsewhere: even when internal parties want de-escalation, external dynamics can pull toward escalation, or vice versa. A key implication for crisis debate is that “de-escalation” has to be negotiated across more than one axis: battlefield restraint, external supply and financing constraints, and political guarantees that make restraint rational rather than suicidal.

Maritime stakes are central to the current phase because Yemen’s ports, coastal routes, and sea access are critical for both humanitarian supply and regional shipping security. Control of ports and coastal areas influences who can regulate imports, who collects revenue, and who can exert leverage through threats to shipping or restrictions on access. The legal and policy sensitivities around blockade, port access, and restrictions on commercial and humanitarian flows are therefore among the most contested issues in the conflict. Delegates should treat port access not as a technical matter but as a strategic and humanitarian hinge: how goods enter Yemen determines both civilian survival and the balance of power among competing authorities. This is also why the UN has repeatedly treated Hodeidah as more than a single city: the Stockholm Agreement (13 December 2018) and the creation of UN support mechanisms (including UNMHA) were designed around the recognition that ports, revenue, and demilitarization arrangements can decide whether a national de-escalation is feasible at all.

Yemen’s conflict landscape includes overlapping domestic factions and external backers, and any workable strategy must begin with a realistic map of who controls territory, institutions, and ports. The most important point for delegates is that “the parties” are not a neat two-sided contest. There are armed movements, political groupings, and local authorities who may align tactically but diverge strategically. Some actors prioritize national political control, others prioritize regional autonomy, and others prioritize maintaining security dominance in a particular zone. This fragmentation means that even if a peace agreement is signed at the national level, implementation can fail unless it reflects the realities of local command structures and the economic interests tied to territory. In practice, Yemen’s fragmentation is reinforced by “dual-use governance”: the same institutions that

should deliver services (customs, port authorities, security forces) are often also tools for coercion, revenue extraction, and political control.

External backers matter not only because they provide material support, but because they can shape what outcomes local partners consider acceptable. Some external actors seek leverage over national governance; others seek security assurances; others seek to prevent threats to maritime routes or borders. These interests can sustain negotiations by guaranteeing compliance, or undermine them by encouraging maximalist demands. Meanwhile, humanitarian agencies and commercial shipping actors are not belligerents, but they are affected stakeholders whose access and safety influence everything from famine prevention to the credibility of ceasefires. Recent dynamics in southern Yemen also illustrate how “intra-coalition” tensions can become conflict drivers of their own, with local power struggles reshaping frontlines and bargaining positions even when the broader war appears frozen.

The legal/policy lens here is consent and legitimacy: who can sign what, and on whose behalf. In Yemen, legitimacy disputes are not theoretical, they determine whether agreements are viewed as binding, whether port authorities can commit to access terms, and whether international actors can lawfully coordinate with certain institutions without appearing to recognize them as the sole legitimate government. Delegates should recognize the practical implication: if an agreement does not include the actors who control relevant territory and infrastructure, it will not be implemented, yet including them raises political concerns about legitimization. This tension is one reason why international processes have oscillated between insisting on a single recognized framework and pragmatically engaging de facto authorities for access, deconfliction, and implementation.

The war persists because governance collapse, economic crisis, and security fragmentation reinforce each other. Governance collapse means that public services, health, education, water, civil administration, either fail outright or become politicized tools of control. When institutions cannot pay salaries, regulate markets, or provide basic security, armed groups become the most organized actors available, and civilians are forced to negotiate survival through whichever authority is nearest. This dynamic turns political identity into a daily calculation: where you live determines the rules you follow, the taxes you pay, and the risks you face. For delegates, the takeaway is that “restoring the state” is not only constitutional design; it is rebuilding administrative routines, salary payment, civil documentation, policing norms, that reduce the need for armed intermediaries.

The economic crisis is not a side effect, it is a core driver. Control over revenue sources such as ports, customs, fuel flows, and taxation systems becomes a strategic objective because the ability to fund armed forces and patronage networks is what sustains power. Currency instability, disrupted trade, and fragmented financial governance deepen hardship, which then increases reliance on informal economies and armed gatekeepers. This also means that ceasefires can falter if they do not address economic arrangements: if parties fear that peace will cut off revenue, they have incentives to stall or sabotage implementation. This is one reason why economic “confidence-building” (port

revenues, salary mechanisms, banking access, fuel import rules) often matters as much as battlefield lines: it changes the payoff structure that keeps war rational for elites.

Security fragmentation compounds these issues by creating multiple armed chains of command with inconsistent discipline and competing local interests. Even where a political leadership may prefer de-escalation, commanders on the ground may benefit from continued fighting, smuggling, or checkpoint taxation. This is why agreements often “hold” in principle but fail in practice: enforcement depends on actors who may not be fully controlled by those who sign the documents. Delegates should treat fragmentation as an implementation problem, not just a description: any plan needs mechanisms that bind local commanders, monitoring, incentives, and credible penalties that do not rely on a single hierarchy that does not exist.

From a legal/policy perspective, sanctions and economic restrictions can further complicate these drivers. While sanctions may be designed to pressure leadership or restrict military capacity, they can unintentionally worsen civilian suffering if they disrupt imports, banking access, or commercial confidence. That is why humanitarian exemptions and precise design matter: the committee should understand that “pressure” tools must be paired with mechanisms that preserve humanitarian and commercial lifelines, otherwise they strengthen the war economy by pushing commerce into informal and exploitable channels. Yemen’s sanctions architecture, renewed repeatedly by the Council, illustrates this balancing act: coercive measures can be politically satisfying, but if they do not change enforcement realities (border control, inspection regimes, financing networks), they can become performative while civilians absorb the shock.

Yemen has seen multiple negotiated texts, ceasefires, confidence-building measures, and political frameworks, yet the persistent gap between agreement language and compliance reality remains the defining challenge. One reason is that negotiated texts often focus on high-level principles while avoiding the operational details that determine whether violence actually decreases: who controls checkpoints, who monitors violations, how disputes are adjudicated, and what consequences follow repeated breaches. Another reason is that partial agreements can stabilize one zone while leaving other fronts unresolved, allowing parties to shift pressure rather than reduce it. Without an integrated national framework that accounts for the fragmentation of authority, compliance becomes selective and reversible. The Hodeidah track under the Stockholm framework is a clear lesson: agreements can create international backing and monitoring structures, but if local incentives to comply remain weak, or if redeployment and revenue arrangements stay contested, implementation stalls and the political value of the text erodes.

A further challenge is that agreements often under-address economic and administrative issues. Even when fighting slows, competition over salaries, customs revenue, port administration, and banking access can reignite conflict because these are the engines of governance and patronage. The absence of credible verification and enforcement mechanisms compounds this: each side doubts the other’s intentions, and spoilers exploit the ambiguity to create incidents that unravel fragile progress. Delegates should therefore treat past agreements as lessons in design: compliance requires

monitoring, incentives, and a structure that aligns local realities with national commitments. Internal political fragmentation adds another layer: even where political texts exist to manage rival “anti-Houthi” authorities, such as the Riyadh Agreement between the Yemeni government and the Southern Transitional Council, implementation frictions show how power-sharing language can fail unless security arrangements, redeployments, and institutional authority are actually made enforceable.

Humanitarian Impact at a Regional and International Level

Yemen’s humanitarian crisis is defined by the collision of food insecurity, health system breakdown, displacement, and severe access constraints. Food insecurity is driven not only by scarcity but by affordability and distribution: when incomes collapse and markets fracture, families can no longer purchase basic staples even when supplies exist. In IR terms, Yemen illustrates how famine risk can be a governance failure as much as an agricultural one, currency fragmentation, salary interruptions, import restrictions, and checkpoint taxation can make hunger predictable even in the presence of food. Health system collapse magnifies every other problem. Preventable diseases become deadly when clinics lack staff, fuel, medicines, cold-chain capacity, or safe access routes, and when the public health infrastructure needed for vaccination, surveillance, and sanitation has been hollowed out by years of conflict. Displacement strains host communities and increases vulnerability to exploitation, while repeated displacement destroys livelihoods and social cohesion, making recovery harder even if fighting slows.

Access constraints are among the most consequential features of Yemen’s humanitarian environment. Delivering aid depends on safe movement, predictable permissions, and the ability to operate without being absorbed into political control systems. Aid agencies often must negotiate across multiple authorities, pass through checkpoints, and manage the risk of diversion or obstruction, including delays, re-routing demands, “taxes,” or pressure to distribute through favored local intermediaries. When humanitarian operations are constrained, the crisis becomes self-reinforcing: poor nutrition and disease reduce community resilience, which increases instability and dependency, which in turn creates new pressure points for armed actors to exploit. The strategic logic is harsh but important for delegates to grasp: restricting access can function as coercion, and controlling access can function as legitimacy, actors who can “allow” aid may claim governance credit even while helping create the conditions that make aid necessary.

The legal/policy lens focuses on humanitarian access and protection of aid workers. For delegates, the key is to treat humanitarian space as an operational system that needs safeguarding: deconfliction channels, transparent distribution mechanisms, monitoring that discourages diversion, and clear commitments from authorities that aid personnel and facilities are protected. This is also where the committee should push into actionable design: corridor arrangements that specify who coordinates movement and how violations are reported; third-party monitoring that does not depend on one faction’s goodwill; and “firewall” policies that separate humanitarian decision-making from political

bargaining as much as possible. In a crisis committee setting, this is where policy proposals can shine, because humanitarian access is one of the few areas where even adversaries sometimes have overlapping interests if incentives are structured properly (for example, linking local compliance to predictable fuel, medical, or import facilitation that benefits civilian stability without rewarding diversion).

Yemen is inseparable from Red Sea and Gulf of Aden security, and that connection shapes the priorities of external stakeholders. The region's maritime corridors carry substantial global trade, energy shipments, and commercial goods, making freedom of navigation a central concern for many states. Yemen's coastal geography and proximity to chokepoints mean that instability can quickly become a maritime security problem, whether through threats to shipping, disruptions to port operations, or increased incentives for illicit trafficking networks. This draws in international naval actors and regional security frameworks, which can contribute to deterrence and protection, while also risking escalation if maritime incidents are politicized or misinterpreted. For delegates, the key takeaway is that maritime insecurity is not separate from Yemen's land war: port governance, coastal control, and revenue collection often shape internal bargaining power, while external maritime responses can alter escalation dynamics onshore.

Yemen's conflict cannot be understood only through domestic fragmentation; it has repeatedly functioned as a proxy arena where regional rivals pursue security and influence objectives through local partners rather than direct interstate war. External sponsorship can intensify the conflict by supplying weapons, training, intelligence support, financing, and diplomatic cover, raising the capacity of local factions and reducing the pressure to compromise. It also reshapes what "victory" means: local actors may be pushed toward maximalist positions if external backers treat Yemen as part of a broader deterrence contest, while external actors may block concessions that would be rational for Yemenis but perceived as strategic loss regionally. For delegates, the major takeaway is that proxy dynamics create a credibility trap: even when internal parties tentatively agree, they may lack autonomy to implement, and spoilers can trigger escalations to signal loyalty or extract more support. Any sustainable humanitarian and political track therefore needs a parallel external track, confidence-building measures, restraint commitments, and verification ideas that reduce the incentives for outside actors to treat Yemen as a pressure valve for wider regional competition.

The legal/policy lens here involves basic law-of-the-sea principles: maritime security operations must balance the protection of shipping with respect for sovereign waters, rules on interdiction, and the distinction between counter-piracy measures and conflict-related enforcement. Delegates should understand that "maritime security" is not just about warships, it is about the rules and coordination structures that determine when a vessel can be stopped, what evidence is required, how proportionality is judged, and how civilian trade is protected. This legal structure becomes especially important when maritime measures intersect with humanitarian flow: aggressive enforcement can disrupt imports and worsen civilian harm, while weak enforcement can allow arms flows or illicit revenue streams to strengthen armed actors. In practice, the hardest policy problem is dual-use: the same shipping networks that sustain civilians can be exploited for military resupply or revenue, so

enforcement that is too blunt harms civilians, and enforcement that is too permissive sustains belligerents.

Key Points of Contention and Key Takeaways

Several disputes will predictably divide delegates. One is ceasefire sequencing versus political settlement sequencing: should the committee push for an immediate and comprehensive ceasefire first, or should ceasefires be tied to concrete political milestones to prevent them from becoming temporary pauses that entrench armed control? Delegates arguing for “ceasefire first” will point to the logic of harm reduction and to precedent: the UN-mediated truce that began in April 2022 showed that even partial arrangements (fuel entry, flights, and reduced hostilities) can lower violence and create space for bargaining when the incentives are clear and the terms are practical. Those favoring “politics first” will counter that Yemen’s institutional fragmentation makes ceasefires fragile unless paired with governance and revenue arrangements, public salary payment, port revenues, and banking access, so that commanders and administrators have something to lose by violating a pause. This debate will sharpen around the UN Special Envoy’s “roadmap” concept: a nationwide ceasefire can be made more durable if bundled with economic steps (salary payments, resuming oil exports, easing restrictions on Sana’a airport and Hudaydah port) and a defined transition into a Yemeni-owned political process under UN auspices.

Delegates will also clash over maritime security versus humanitarian flow. Some will prioritize strict maritime measures to prevent arms smuggling and protect shipping; others will warn that excessive restrictions can choke Yemen’s import lifeline, worsen hunger, and inadvertently strengthen black markets controlled by armed groups. The immediate IR friction here is that maritime governance is both security policy and economic warfare: inspections, rerouting, and port controls can reduce illicit flows, but they can also raise transaction costs, delay fuel and food, and push commerce toward informal channels. Yemen-specific mechanisms illustrate the “middle path” argument: UNVIM was operationalized to facilitate commercial cargo to Red Sea ports while addressing Security Council concerns linked to the sanctions framework, an attempt to keep imports moving without treating all shipping as suspect. The maritime dispute will also be shaped by the post-2023 Red Sea escalation: Security Council resolution 2722 (2024) condemned attacks on merchant and commercial vessels and demanded they cease, reinforcing that navigational rights and global commerce can pull the Yemen file into wider international security responses that may not align neatly with humanitarian priorities.

A third contention involves external guarantees versus sovereignty objections. External guarantees, monitoring missions, international guarantors, naval coalitions, or regional security commitments, can make agreements more credible by raising the cost of violations and reducing “he said, she said” dynamics. But they can also be viewed as infringements on sovereignty or as biased interventions that favor one side, especially when legitimacy is contested and foreign involvement is already part of the conflict’s structure. Delegates who favor guarantees will cite the logic behind internationally

backed arrangements such as the Stockholm Agreement's Hudaydah track and the establishment of UNMHA to support implementation: Yemen's fragmentation often requires a third-party buffer simply to translate commitments into observable steps. Those skeptical of guarantees will argue that "internationalization" can become a substitute for domestic political settlement, and that enforcement bodies can be politicized or become targets, especially when local command structures are not unified.

A fourth, closely linked dispute will be sanctions/pressure tools versus "keeping the door open." Some delegates will argue that targeted sanctions and arms controls are necessary leverage and norm enforcement, pointing to the Security Council's Yemen sanctions regime under resolution 2140 (2014) and the expanded framework in resolution 2216 (2015), which also treats obstruction of humanitarian assistance as a designation criterion. Others will argue that pressure can harden positions, incentivize smuggling and war-economy adaptation, and make de-escalation politically costly for parties that fear being "punished into compromise." In practice, crisis committees thrive when delegates are forced to specify design: if sanctions are proposed, who investigates and attributes violations (e.g., Panel of Experts reporting), what triggers listings, and what humanitarian safeguards prevent civilian harm?

In Yemen's context, these disputes are especially sharp because legitimacy is contested and external involvement is already part of the conflict's structure. The best delegate strategies will therefore be those that propose layered solutions: ceasefire mechanisms with clear verification; humanitarian flow protections built into maritime arrangements (e.g., predictable inspection timelines and protected import corridors); and external support designed as oversight and enforcement rather than political domination. A credible "layered" approach also anticipates fragmentation: national-level agreements should be paired with local compliance mechanisms, because commanders who profit from checkpoints and smuggling will not automatically obey signatures made in distant negotiating rooms.

Internal Factions and Political Breakdown should emphasize how fractured legitimacy and parallel governance systems make Yemen's war resistant to simple "two-party" solutions. Delegates should treat Yemen as a patchwork of authorities with overlapping but non-identical interests, where implementation fails when excluded actors control the roads, ports, and security units that matter. The Riyadh Agreement experience in the south illustrates the point: even when nominal allies sign power-sharing texts, security integration and command unification can remain contested, keeping the internal "anti-Houthi" arena unstable and politically fragmented.

Regional Power Involvement should explain how external backing shapes negotiation leverage and escalation dynamics while tying Yemen to broader regional deterrence and influence contests. Delegates should make explicit that external actors can both enable peace (by guaranteeing compliance and providing economic relief) and sabotage it (by incentivizing maximalism or using Yemen as a pressure front for unrelated disputes). The Yemen file is therefore not only about persuading local factions, it is about aligning external incentives so that restraint is strategically "worth it."

Humanitarian Access and Civilian Suffering should remain the connective thread across all parts of the analysis, showing how ports, economic measures, military choices, and legal frameworks translate directly into whether civilians survive, and whether any peace process can achieve durable legitimacy. The core takeaway is that humanitarian outcomes are not peripheral metrics; they are political facts that shape recruitment, legitimacy, and the feasibility of any settlement. A plan that cannot keep imports flowing, pay salaries, and protect aid space is not just morally weak, it is strategically unstable.

F. Somalia

Introduction to the Issues

Somalia is often summarized as a counterterrorism challenge, but that framing is too narrow for understanding why the country's crises persist and why they repeatedly re-emerge even after apparent gains. Somalia is better approached as a nexus of three intertwined struggles: long-term state-building, an enduring insurgency, and a maritime security environment that links coastal insecurity to regional and global trade routes. These three dynamics constantly shape one another. Weak governance and contested legitimacy make it harder to build reliable security forces; insecurity then prevents institutions from delivering services and earning public trust; and the resulting vacuum fuels both land-based armed groups and coastal illicit economies. In this sense, Somalia is not a "single emergency" but a chronic political-security condition in which progress is real but fragile, often dependent on sustained external support, internal political bargains that remain incomplete, and a security environment that can shift quickly when incentives change. The current international architecture reflects this reality: the Security Council authorized the transition from AMISOM to ATMIS to support a phased handover of security responsibilities to Somali forces and explicitly stressed that military action alone is insufficient without governance, rule of law, and inclusive politics.

Somalia's "silent war" character lies in how normal life is repeatedly forced to adapt to insecurity rather than overcome it. Communities develop coping mechanisms, informal justice, private protection, remittance-based survival, localized governance, yet these adaptations can also entrench fragmentation and weaken national cohesion. Meanwhile, international attention tends to spike around singular events, major attacks, piracy surges, election crises, before fading, even though the underlying structural pressures remain. For crisis delegates, Somalia is a case study in how long-term political design problems can become security crises, and how security responses that ignore governance realities tend to produce temporary stabilization rather than durable peace. Even "good news" moments, territory reclaimed, an election completed, a new coordination agreement announced, can be reversible if they do not translate into predictable administration, dispute resolution, and livelihood security for communities living at the margins of state reach.

Somalia's present situation reflects a prolonged effort to rebuild a state after decades of institutional collapse, while simultaneously fighting an insurgency that exploits governance deficits and societal fractures. Unlike conflicts that hinge on one decisive battlefield contest, Somalia's struggle is about building authority that can be accepted as legitimate across diverse regions and communities. That is a slow process even in stable environments; in Somalia it unfolds under the pressure of armed attacks, political competition, and the constant risk that institutions remain dependent on personalities and external resources rather than durable systems. This is why federal-regional bargaining is not "background politics", it determines whether security forces coordinate, whether revenue is shared, and whether local administrations treat national institutions as credible.

Counterinsurgency remains central because insurgent violence is not merely disruptive, it is strategically designed to prevent the consolidation of governance. Attacks often target government presence, public confidence, and economic activity, reinforcing the message that the state cannot protect its citizens. This undermines taxation, service delivery, and recruitment into legitimate security forces, which then weakens the state further. At the same time, Somalia's coastline and maritime geography connect domestic insecurity to broader regional dynamics. When governance is weak on land, illicit trade networks, smuggling, trafficking, and episodic piracy, find more room to operate. Maritime insecurity, in turn, draws in international actors and creates external priorities that may not always align neatly with Somali political realities. The recent resurgence warnings around Somali piracy activity underscore the point that "suppressed" is not the same as "solved": capability can persist, and opportunity can return quickly when enforcement or onshore deterrence weakens.

The legal and policy lens for this background emphasizes state capacity and legitimacy, as well as the boundaries of external support. Somalia's government depends on international assistance for security, financing, and institution-building, yet that dependence raises difficult questions: how to ensure Somali ownership, how to avoid substituting external actors for domestic legitimacy, and how to prevent security assistance from empowering abusive or unaccountable forces. Delegates should treat external support not as a binary ("help" versus "no help") but as a design challenge: the form and conditions of assistance determine whether it builds sustainable capacity or temporarily props up fragile arrangements. This design challenge is sharpened by Security Council decisions that reshape the operating environment, such as resolution 2714 (2023) lifting the long-standing general arms embargo on deliveries to Somalia's government, a move intended to strengthen Somali security capacity but one that also raises downstream questions about oversight, diversion risk, and regional perceptions.

Somalia's political and security ecosystem is shaped by federal versus regional dynamics, insurgent actors, international support missions, and maritime stakeholders who care about trade security and coastal stability. At the center is the federal government, which claims national authority and represents Somalia internationally, but whose effective reach is often uneven and contested. Federal Member States and regional authorities play an outsized role because they control local security structures, political constituencies, and revenue systems, sometimes cooperating with the center, sometimes resisting it, and often negotiating constantly over power-sharing, resources, and

jurisdiction. These dynamics are not just political theater; they directly shape security outcomes because coordination failures create gaps that armed groups exploit. ATMIS itself was mandated around this logic: phased handover and capacity-building are only viable if Somali security forces are integrated and command-and-control is credible across federal and regional lines.

Insurgent actors operate within this fractured political environment, adapting to local conditions and exploiting disputes between elites. Where federal-regional relations are tense, insurgents can present themselves as the more predictable authority, offering coercive “order,” dispute resolution, or economic access in exchange for compliance. Meanwhile, community militias and clan-aligned security actors can serve as both stabilizers and accelerants of conflict, depending on whether they are integrated into accountable command structures or left to operate as localized power centers. International actors, particularly AU- and UN-supported missions and associated training and funding mechanisms, remain major security enablers. Their presence can provide critical operational capacity, logistics, and protection for population centers, but it also becomes politically sensitive: when external forces are central to security, questions arise about sovereignty, dependency, and long-term sustainability. Maritime stakeholders include regional navies, international maritime coalitions, shipping interests, coastal communities, and port-related authorities. Their priorities often center on freedom of navigation and preventing piracy or trafficking, but their actions intersect with Somali governance because coastal security cannot be separated from onshore authority.

The legal and policy lens here focuses on security assistance accountability and human rights safeguards. In practice, this means: who trains and equips which forces, what oversight exists, how allegations of abuse are addressed, and whether assistance is conditioned on compliance with humanitarian and human rights standards. For delegates, this is a crucial point: support that improves operational capability but ignores accountability can deepen mistrust and fuel insurgent narratives, undermining the very stabilization it aims to achieve. Security Council guidance on ATMIS also embeds these expectations, emphasizing compliance with international humanitarian and human rights law and the importance of accountability mechanisms within the mission and its partners.

Somalia’s conflict drivers sit at the intersection of governance deficits, clan politics, economic incentives, and insurgency strategy. Governance deficits are not simply “lack of capacity”; they include contested authority, inconsistent service delivery, politicized security provision, and limited access to impartial justice. When citizens experience the state as absent, predatory, or captured by rival interests, they are less likely to cooperate with security forces, pay taxes, or accept national institutions as legitimate. This creates a structural vulnerability that insurgents exploit by presenting themselves, however coercively, as a consistent alternative.

Clan politics is often misunderstood as the cause of conflict, when it is more accurately a political reality that shapes how power is organized, mediated, and contested. Clan affiliation influences local trust, leadership legitimacy, dispute resolution, and mobilization. When national political design fails to accommodate or fairly balance these realities, competition can escalate into conflict or

institutional paralysis. Economic incentives reinforce this: control of checkpoints, ports, trade corridors, charcoal or commodity routes, and informal taxation systems can make fragmentation profitable. Where politics becomes a route to economic control, compromise becomes harder because power-sharing is not only about representation, it is about revenue and security dominance.

Insurgency thrives in this environment because it is not just a military contest; it is a governance contest. Insurgents exploit corruption narratives, deliver swift (if brutal) dispute resolution, and punish collaboration to isolate communities from the state. They also exploit cycles of retaliation and civilian harm. When counterterror operations produce civilian casualties, abuses, or perceived collective punishment, it creates grievances that insurgents convert into recruitment and compliance. This is why Somalia's conflict cannot be reduced to "defeat the insurgents": long-term stability depends on reducing the governance and economic conditions that make insurgent influence rational for communities trying to survive.

The legal/policy tension highlighted here, local reconciliation versus national political design, is one of Somalia's defining dilemmas. Local reconciliation can reduce immediate violence and stabilize communities, but it may entrench localized power arrangements that complicate national cohesion. National political design can create clearer authority and uniform policy, but if imposed without local legitimacy it can provoke resistance and deepen fragmentation. Delegates should be encouraged to treat this tension as a strategic choice: what balance of local autonomy and national authority is feasible, and what mechanisms can prevent autonomy from becoming permanent fragmentation?

Somalia has seen real stabilization gains at various moments, territory reclaimed, institutions strengthened, elections held, yet these gains often reverse because the underlying system remains fragile and highly contingent. One reason is mission transitions and drawdowns: when international missions reduce presence or shift mandates, security gaps can emerge faster than Somali forces can fill them. This is not simply a matter of troop numbers; it is about logistics, air support, intelligence, pay systems, and command cohesion. If a transition plan assumes capacity that does not exist yet, insurgents can exploit the vacuum immediately, precisely the risk ATMIS was designed to manage through phased handover timelines rather than abrupt exits.

Funding and mandate issues also destabilize progress. Stabilization is expensive and requires predictable financing for salaries, training, governance programs, and humanitarian support. When funding is uncertain or politicized, it creates delays in pay, reduces morale, increases corruption risk, and weakens coordination between federal and regional forces. Mandate constraints can further limit effectiveness: support missions may be expected to protect civilians and enable governance while being restricted in how they can use force or where they can deploy. Past agreements sometimes fail because they are elite bargains without durable implementation mechanisms, power-sharing deals that do not resolve revenue allocation, command structure disputes, or local grievances, leaving the same triggers in place for future crises.

Delegates should treat these efforts not as failures to dismiss but as lessons: sustainable stabilization requires sequencing that matches capacity, financing that matches timelines, and political settlements that incorporate both national-level legitimacy and local-level acceptance. Without those foundations, Somalia's progress risks remaining episodic, real, but reversible.

Somalia's regional and international dimensions are dominated by maritime insecurity and broader spillover risks. Maritime insecurity matters because Somalia's coastline sits along routes crucial to international commerce, and because coastal instability can translate quickly into piracy, smuggling, arms trafficking, and illicit financial flows. Even when piracy is not at peak levels, the enabling conditions, weak coastal governance, economic desperation, criminal networks, and opportunity, can remain. This creates a constant watchfulness by international naval forces and shipping stakeholders, and it encourages a security approach that prioritizes protection of shipping lanes. However, maritime stability cannot be maintained indefinitely through offshore patrols alone; it depends on onshore authority, legal institutions capable of prosecution, and coastal communities having livelihoods that do not reward criminal enterprise.

Regionally, Somalia's insecurity affects neighbors through refugee flows, cross-border militant movement, and regional political competition. Neighboring states may support different Somali actors, pursue buffer-zone strategies, or intervene to protect their own security, actions that can stabilize certain areas while inflaming sovereignty disputes and internal political tensions. The interaction between regional security interests and Somali internal politics creates a delicate environment where external action can be both necessary and destabilizing depending on coordination, transparency, and perceived neutrality.

The legal/policy lens on maritime operations emphasizes authority, jurisdiction, and coordination. Effective counter-piracy and maritime security operations require clarity about who can interdict vessels, where suspects can be detained, which courts have jurisdiction, and how evidence is handled across borders. Coordination is equally important: multiple naval actors, regional states, and Somali authorities must align rules of engagement and information sharing, otherwise enforcement becomes inconsistent and legitimacy suffers. Delegates should understand that maritime security is as much a legal architecture problem as it is an operational one, and that failures in legal coordination can undermine deterrence even when naval capacity exists.

Key Points of Contention and Take aways

The committee should anticipate sharp debate over mission drawdown versus security vacuum risk. Some delegates will argue that prolonged external presence undermines sovereignty, fosters dependency, and delays Somali ownership, especially when core security functions (air support, logistics, stipends, and joint planning) remain externally enabled. Others will argue that premature withdrawal creates a vacuum that insurgents will fill, reversing years of progress and worsening civilian suffering. This debate is often framed as a moral question, but it is also a technical one: what

benchmarks define readiness, what capabilities must be transferred first, and what transitional support remains even after drawdown? The Security Council's recent transition decisions illustrate the stakes: resolution 2748 (2024) extended ATMIS authorization and framed the handover as phased and conditions-based, while resolution 2767 (2024) shifted the architecture toward the post-ATMIS successor mission (AUSSOM), underscoring that "exit" is really a redesign of external support rather than a clean departure.

Counterterror operations versus civilian harm concerns will also divide delegates. Some will prioritize aggressive action to degrade insurgent capacity, arguing that without pressure the insurgency will persist indefinitely and continue to generate regional spillover. Others will emphasize that civilian harm, whether from airstrikes, raids, abusive detention, or collective punishment dynamics, undermines legitimacy and becomes a strategic gift to insurgents. The practical challenge is designing counterterror approaches that are precise, accountable, and paired with protection measures, so operations reduce insurgent influence rather than expand it through grievance. Recent UN reporting continues to describe Al-Shabaab as a leading threat to peace and stability and highlights how its coercive finance and intimidation networks exploit governance gaps, meaning that "kinetic success" without governance and protection can still fail strategically.

Finally, centralization versus federal autonomy will shape political proposals. Centralizers will argue that Somalia cannot stabilize without a coherent national command structure, predictable revenue collection, and unified institutions that can plan, pay, and deploy security forces consistently. Federalists will argue that Somalia's legitimacy depends on meaningful regional autonomy and locally accepted governance, and that forced centralization will provoke resistance and fragmentation, especially where Federal Member States view the center as a rival rather than a partner. The best crisis strategies will not simply choose one side; they will propose mechanisms that manage the tension, clear division of powers, revenue-sharing arrangements, security sector integration with safeguards, and dispute resolution channels that prevent political disagreement from becoming armed confrontation. This is also where delegates should connect politics to operational security: coordination breakdowns are not abstract constitutional debates; they create exploitable seams that insurgents use to move, tax, recruit, and punish collaboration.

Governance and State Capacity Challenges should trace how legitimacy, service delivery, justice, and institutional coherence determine whether security gains endure. Delegates should link this to the "systems" side of stabilization: payroll reliability, corruption controls, local dispute resolution, and civilian-facing administration that reduces the appeal of insurgent parallel courts and coercive taxation.

Terrorism and Maritime Insecurity should connect land-based insurgency to coastal dynamics and regional shipping security, showing how both depend on governance and economic incentives. Somalia's piracy risk is a useful reminder that maritime threats can re-emerge when onshore deterrence weakens or when regional maritime disruption changes incentives; recent incidents

reported by international media and naval forces show that capability and opportunity can return even after years of decline.

International Intervention and Peacebuilding Efforts should explain how external missions, funding, and diplomatic frameworks can stabilize Somalia, yet also how they can unintentionally entrench dependency or political fragmentation if not carefully structured around Somali ownership, accountability, and realistic transition benchmarks. Security Council choices matter here: the lifting of the general arms embargo on Somalia's government under resolution 2714 (2023) is often defended as capacity-building, but it also raises committee-relevant questions about oversight, diversion risk, and conditioning support on accountability standards so that "more capacity" does not translate into more abuse or more fragmentation.

IV. Positions of Key States and Stakeholders

State Actors

In a “silent war” environment, state positions are rarely just about battlefield outcomes, they’re about survival, legitimacy, and control over who gets to use force. Governments caught in protracted conflict typically prioritize regime continuity and territorial integrity first, then negotiate outward from there: they want international recognition as the sole legitimate authority, predictable external financing, and security support that strengthens the state rather than empowering rivals inside it. This often produces a consistent pattern in diplomacy, states emphasize sovereignty and non-interference while simultaneously requesting “capacity-building,” intelligence, training, equipment, or budget support. The tension is that external support can stabilize a government in the short term, but it can also deepen grievances if it reinforces abusive security services, excludes marginalized communities, or bypasses local governance.

State positions are also shaped by how fragmented the state is. In federal or devolved systems, “the state” is not one actor: central authorities, regional administrations, security agencies, and political elites may push competing lines, one seeking compromise talks, another pursuing militarized escalation, and another bargaining for resource control or autonomy. Even where a government speaks with one voice internationally, its internal political settlement often depends on balancing elites, clan/ethnic coalitions, patronage networks, and security actors. That’s why many states prefer externally backed solutions that are incremental and managerial (e.g., security-sector reform, DDR, elections, revenue systems) rather than transformative political arrangements that could reorder internal power.

Finally, state actors are highly attentive to legal and reputational exposure. They often resist intrusive monitoring but still need legitimacy and funding, so they may accept conditionality in forms that preserve face: joint oversight mechanisms, “technical” compliance benchmarks, time-limited mandates, or hybrid missions. This is where “authority” matters in practice: states will constantly debate whether actions should be grounded in host-state consent, regional authorization, or UN Security Council mandates, because each basis shifts who can pressure whom, and how far.

Regional Actors

Regional actors, especially neighbors, tend to treat these crises as spillover problems first and normative problems second. Their positions are driven by border security, refugee flows, arms trafficking, cross-border insurgency, and domestic political risk (because conflict entrepreneurs and extremist narratives rarely stop at a frontier). This makes regional states simultaneously fearful of escalation and reluctant to cut ties with whichever armed actors control borderlands, smuggling routes, or strategic corridors. As a result, they often back strategies that mix hard containment (border forces, joint patrols, intelligence sharing) with

pragmatic engagement (mediation, local ceasefires, “community stabilization,” trade corridors).

Regional diplomacy is also shaped by rivalries and competing regional orders. Neighboring states may support different factions not because of ideology, but because they want leverage over trade routes, ports, river basins, or buffer zones. That rivalry frequently plays out through regional blocs and ad hoc coalitions, producing dueling “peace processes,” parallel mediation tracks, and fragmented sanctions policies. In committee terms, this is why you’ll see repeated contestation over who “leads” a process, because leadership equals agenda-setting power, recognition, and access to external funding.

The regional layer is where institutions become tools rather than just forums. These include a range of sub-regional groupings (for example ECOWAS, IGAD, EAC, ECCAS, SADC, and ICGLR) plus political-security alignments like the Alliance of Sahel States (AES). These bodies serve as vehicles for neighbors to formalize collective positions, on unconstitutional changes of government, cross-border counterterrorism, peace talks, or the conditions under which outside forces can operate. Regional actors often prefer these venues because they allow them to argue that decisions reflect “regional ownership,” even when states inside the region disagree sharply on what ownership should mean.

Major Powers

Major powers typically approach these crises through a combined lens of strategic competition, counterterrorism, maritime and energy security, migration pressures, and international credibility. Their positions are rarely uniform across theaters: what looks like a principled stance (human rights, sovereignty, stabilization, democracy) often shifts depending on whether a given conflict intersects with shipping lanes, rival power influence, military basing, critical minerals, or domestic political constraints. In practice, major powers are most influential when they can control or coordinate:

- (1) money,
- (2) weapons,
- (3) diplomatic recognition, and
- (4) the rules of international authorization.

The biggest formal “authority amplifier” is the UN Security Council, especially when major powers are permanent members. The Council can authorize missions, impose sanctions, create monitoring regimes, and shape the global narrative of legitimacy. But the same structure also creates paralysis: major powers may block resolutions that constrain their partners, restrict arms sales, expose proxy relationships, or establish accountability mechanisms that could later be used against them. That’s why “silent war” diplomacy often migrates to less formal channels, contact groups, bilateral security packages, intelligence

partnerships, and parallel mediation tracks, while still using UN language to preserve legitimacy.

Major powers also work through extra-regional institutions, such as the EU and NATO (and, in other alignments, groupings like SCO and CSTO). These frameworks matter less as “actors on the ground” and more as coordination engines: they standardize training, intelligence cooperation, sanctions alignment, border-management programming, and funding pipelines. In negotiations, major powers often push “package solutions” (ceasefire + transitional roadmap + aid + security-sector reform), but the package’s credibility depends on whether regional organizations and local state actors see it as stabilizing, or as an attempt to lock in an external balance of power.

Non-State Actors and Their Influence

Non-state actors shape the battlefield and the bargaining table because they frequently control the three things states struggle to monopolize: coercion, local legitimacy, and revenue. This category includes insurgent groups and extremist networks, community militias and self-defense forces, political movements with armed wings, criminal trafficking networks, piracy and maritime predation systems, and private military/security providers. In “silent war” contexts, these actors thrive in the seams between jurisdictions, borderlands, disputed towns, ungoverned maritime spaces, and informal economies, where state authority is partial and external assistance is uneven.

Their influence is not only kinetic. Many armed groups provide shadow governance, taxation, courts, protection rackets, recruitment pipelines, and dispute resolution, turning violence into a political economy. Criminal networks in particular can be “system integrators,” linking mining zones, fuel routes, weapons flows, and diaspora finance. That means they can spoil peace processes even when they are not formal signatories, because they profit from fragmentation and can disrupt logistics, elections, or humanitarian access at low cost. Meanwhile, civil society groups, religious networks, and humanitarian organizations can either de-escalate (through mediation, service delivery, community trust) or become targets and symbols in the information war.

Non-state actors also exploit the governance dilemmas major powers and regional actors create. If external partners prioritize quick counterterrorism wins, armed groups frame themselves as “resistance” and recruit. If sanctions are broad and enforcement is selective, black markets expand and war economies consolidate. If political settlements exclude local power brokers, armed entrepreneurs gain incentives to escalate to re-enter negotiations. In committee terms, any strategy that ignores non-state incentives, money, immunity, recognition, territorial control, will struggle, even if it looks strong on paper.

Regional Organizations and their Roles

Regional organizations matter because they sit at the intersection of **legitimacy and enforcement**. They provide the language of “regional ownership,” the machinery for mediation, and, sometimes, the political cover for coercive measures like sanctions, suspensions, and peace support operations. The region and international order offers up a dense ecosystem: the **African Union (AU)** as the continental anchor; sub-regional bodies such as **ECOWAS** (West Africa), **IGAD** (Horn of Africa), **EAC** (East Africa), **ECCAS** (Central Africa), **SADC** (Southern Africa), and the **ICGLR** (Great Lakes); alongside Arab and Gulf frameworks like the **Arab League**, **GCC**, and **OIC**. Each organization’s “authority” is different: some are strongest at diplomacy and norms, others at mobilizing regional troops, and others at coordinating finance, border policy, or political recognition.

In practice, these organizations play five recurring roles. First, **agenda-setting and mediation**: appointing envoys, convening talks, and defining what counts as a legitimate transition. Second, **norm enforcement**: especially around coups, elections, constitutional order, and state fragmentation, often through suspensions, communiqués, and conditional reintegration. Third, **security coordination**: joint operations, intelligence sharing, and peace support missions, sometimes in partnership with the UN. Fourth, **humanitarian and stabilization coordination**: aligning humanitarian access, refugee responses, and early recovery programs with political processes. Fifth, **bridging to global authority**: translating regional consensus into UN action (or blocking UN action by demonstrating regional dissent).

Their main constraint is that they are **member-state driven**, so they reflect regional politics rather than override them. When member states are divided, organizations can produce competing mandates, overlapping missions, or fragile compromises that lack enforcement. Funding and logistics are another limiter, regional missions often depend on external donors, which reintroduces major-power leverage through budgets, equipment, and conditionality. This is why the most durable approaches usually treat regional organizations as **co-authors** of the strategy rather than mere implementers: they can lend legitimacy, but they need coherent state buy-in, credible resources, and clear coordination with UN frameworks to avoid becoming one more arena where the “silent war” is fought diplomatically.

V. Conclusion

This committee's goal is not to "solve" the Silent War in three days; it is to prove that smart, disciplined decision-making can interrupt the cycles that keep these conflicts quiet, chronic, and contagious. A good outcome is one where delegates leave the room having produced an action agenda, a set of choices that clearly answers: what happens first, who does it, with what authority, using what resources, and how success (or failure) will be measured. In practical terms, your end-product should look like a sequenced package rather than a wish list: immediate stabilizers that prevent collapse, enforceable mechanisms that change behavior, and longer-term reforms that make renewed violence less profitable and less politically useful.

Across the Sahel, Nigeria, the DRC, Sudan, Yemen, and Somalia, the Silent War is held together by repeating patterns that reinforce each other. First, fragile or contested state authority creates gaps in security and services, gaps that armed groups fill through coercion, taxation, and parallel governance. Second, war economies turn violence into a livelihood: smuggling, illicit taxation, resource capture, trafficking, and corruption make conflict self-financing and peace inconvenient. Third, regional spillover ensures that no crisis stays neatly inside borders; fighters, weapons, refugees, and money move faster than institutions do. Fourth, external involvement, whether through military assistance, proxy support, or selective diplomacy, often stabilizes one problem while unintentionally feeding another, especially when legitimacy and accountability are treated as optional extras. Finally, the human cost remains the through-line: civilians are not only caught in crossfire; they are frequently used as leverage. Siege tactics, displacement, aid obstruction, and narrative warfare transform survival itself into a battleground. That is why the committee must treat humanitarian access, civilian protection, and governance legitimacy as core security issues, not side quests.

To reach that "good outcome," the committee must make real decisions on mandates (what exactly international and regional actors are empowered to do), resources (who funds and sustains operations), compliance (how spoilers are deterred or constrained), and political pathways (what settlement or governance trajectory your plan is aiming toward). If your resolution cannot survive first contact with reality, armed actors, border politics, budget limits, humanitarian access, and propaganda, it is not a solution; it is a speech. The Silent War rewards vague promises. Your job is to punish vagueness with specificity. A strong crisis response is not the loudest plan, it is the plan that can be implemented, defended, and sustained. Delegates should evaluate proposals using four shared criteria: feasibility (can it actually be carried out with realistic capacity and funding?), legitimacy (does it have lawful authority and local buy-in, or will it be rejected as imposed?), impact (does it measurably reduce violence and suffering, rather than shifting it elsewhere?), and enforcement (what happens when actors refuse, cheat, or spoil?). The best solutions will balance the following tensions without pretending they do not exist:

1. Immediate Security Threats
2. Protection of Civilians and Humanitarian Access
3. Sovereignty vs. International Intervention

4. Long-Term Stability and Conflict Prevention

Lastly, Safal and I would like to wish you all the best for the MUN ahead. Much love and can't wait to see you all soon <3

Annex I: Position Paper Guidelines

Guidelines for position paper

Please note that the following guideline is for a Position Paper, which works as a research document. Position papers for both topics must be written separately. In their position papers, delegates must include a coat of arms of their country at the top. They must clearly mention the committee name, the name of the country they are representing, their own name and the topic under discussion. A sample position paper can be found on the next page.

We strongly recommend you to follow the order outlined below:

1. A thesis statement that clearly indicates your country's position on the issue being discussed. There is no need to state the obvious, such as defining key terms. For example, if the issue under discussion is the "Legality and Effectiveness of Combat Drones", it is not necessary that you define what drones are (everybody in the committee, including the dais members, will know what drones are anyway.) Rather, jump to your stance: you support the use of combat drones or you don't.
2. Develop your stance with accurate facts and figures. Take full advantage of the speeches made by your country's politicians and heads of states. Tell us what your country has done in the past; this helps us understand your country's position on the issue. Be warned, however, that this involves not merely listing out the actions your country has taken. You must explain why your country took some actions and not others.
3. You may include counter-arguments. Be aware that other countries may challenge your viewpoints. Acknowledge a possible argument that your opposition might make. Take up that argument and present a possible counter-argument. This can be done, for example, in the following way: "Some countries like Country X believes that our actions have been wrong; however, we think that..."
4. Solutions. Your proposed solutions carry the most weight in the position paper. Propose solutions and make commitments for the future. Remember that you may write your solutions in paragraphs or in bullet points. Either way, make sure that they are concrete and detailed. In the past, we have often had delegates suggesting solutions of the kind "All countries must work together to solve this issue." These solutions are obvious and far from useful. Be creative and suggest innovative, detailed and concrete solutions to impress your dais members.

Caveats:

1. Remember that you are representing a country, not your own viewpoints. You might personally be in support of a certain issue, but the country you are representing might not. Refrain from using "I believe", "I think"; instead use "We believe", "We think."

2. When you use facts and figures, make sure you back them up. Use superscripted numbers on these facts and later provide their reference. Use an appropriate reference format.
3. Use Font: Garamond, Font size 12 with normal line spacing in all your position papers. Though there is no word limit, we suggest you cap each position paper to one page or one and a half pages.

SAMPLE POSITION PAPER



Committee: United Nations Environment Programme

Country: Republic of Korea

Name: Abinav Singh Thapa

Topic: The need to minimize Transboundary Air Pollution

Trans-boundary air pollution has quickly grown from an environmental to a major health and economic problem for numerous countries. The Republic of Korea supports all necessary measures to minimise this major international threat.

A recently released report states that over 2 million people die every year as a result of atmospheric air pollution.¹ Realising that the need to minimise trans-boundary air pollution is crucial, the Republic of Korea has formulated concrete plans and policies to counter the risks that we are faced with.

The Clean Air Conservation Act is the principal legal framework to minimise air pollution. It focuses mainly on four vital areas: the improvement of air quality in metropolitan areas, minimisation of pollution from businesses, transports and the control of dust and sandstorms. Scientific and technical methods to meet pollution goals are also covered under this act. Korea therefore not only encourages the production of low-pollution cars but also requires catalytic converters to be fixed with vehicles and pollution engines to be modified.

Moreover, we realise that the utilisation of renewable energy is indispensable to curbing pollution. Thus, South Korea is spending over 85 billion US dollars in the development and research of green

industries.² We have also subsidized the installation of a few renewable technologies by up to 80 per cent.³

South Korea is also working actively in the international arena to minimise the threats of trans-boundary air pollution. Though, like all Asian countries, it is not yet a member of the Convention on Long-Range Transboundary Air pollution, it is working with China and Japan under the Tripartite Policy

Dialogue on Air Pollution to exchange technical knowhow and collaborate in research to curb trans-boundary air pollution.

South Korea identifies the main problem in tackling trans-boundary air pollution as the lack of a central treaty that legally binds nations to reduce their pollution. The Convention on Long-Range Transboundary Air-Pollution, with a focus on the UNECE region, has been ratified only by 51 nations. South Korea will push for a separate treaty to be signed in the UNEP which covers all regions.

Having noted that developing countries are also responsible for air pollution, South Korea will support these countries with the finances and the scientific applications required to minimise the release of air pollutants. We also suggest establishing an inter-governmental forum where developing countries will be assisted to keep up with the latest scientific devices to counter air pollution. South Korea will urge members of the G20 Nations to subsidise these devices for developing countries. In such a context, the methods of using renewable resources, such as bio-mass and new devices such as Nox burners should also be promoted.

It is also imperative for tighter restrictions to be placed on polluting industries. We will press for coal to be abandoned as much as possible, since the effects of the air pollution it generates are detrimental.⁴ All countries should focus their investment from coal to natural gas or other renewable alternatives immediately.

Before another 2 million people die this year, all of countries should work immediately to minimise trans-boundary air pollution.

Bibliography

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2. <http://www.reuters.com/article/2009/07/06/us-korea-greengrowth-idUSTRE5651Y720090706>
3. <http://www.businessgreen.com/bg/news/1803593/south-korea-unveils-80-cent-subsidy-domestic-fuel-cells>
4. <http://www.time.com/time/health/article/0,8599,1870599,00.html>

Annex II - Rules of Procedures

In order to simulate the real Food and Agriculture Organization, the committee will follow standard UNA/USA Rules of Procedures (ROPs). Delegates will be referred to as “Delegates,” as per diplomatic standards that are in practice in a formal parliamentary setting. So, to begin with all delegates must address one another appropriately and refer to one another as “Delegate of [Name of Country they are representing].”

Although the general structure of the Rules of Procedure remains similar, each committee session will begin with the Roll Call, followed by the Agenda of the Day. For the majority of the sessions please note that we will abide by UNA/USA guidelines. **I am providing the standard explanation of UNA/USA RoPs that a first timer might not want to miss out on.** If you do not understand the following, we will also have a briefing session before jumping into the actual discussion as a committee, for now simply familiarize yourself with the main forum for discussion that goes in a formal-parliamentary session. If you are familiar with them you can skip forward but for all the first timers enjoy the procedural mandates provide below:

Roll

Call

At the beginning of each committee session, the Chairperson will call the committee to order and initiate Roll Call to determine attendance. Delegates must respond with either “Present” or “Present and Voting.” The latter signifies that the delegate must vote either “Yes” or “No” on all substantive matters, as abstentions are not permitted. If you choose the former you do get to “Abstain” from the vote, while it literally means to refrain from voting, in MUNs it is taken as a reelection of one’s neutral foreign policy. Once Roll Call is completed, the President will proceed to the setting of the agenda.

Setting

the

Agenda

The agenda determines the order in which topics will be discussed. If multiple topics are available, delegates may motion to set the agenda, suggesting a specific order for debate. The Chair will entertain a limited number of speakers for and against the proposed order before proceeding to a vote. The Agenda must be raised in the form of a motion, which means that it must be stated in the required format. A simple majority is required to pass an agenda-setting motion. If no agenda order receives a majority vote, the committee will enter an unmoderated caucus to discuss the matter informally until a consensus is reached.

General

Speakers’

List

After setting the agenda, the committee will begin debate on the first topic. The Chair will open a General Speakers’ List (GSL) after a simple majority assents a **“Motion to Start the GSL”**, where delegates may add their names to speak on the topic. Each speaker is allotted a predetermined amount of time, as set by the committee, which in the case of our committee will set to the standard 90 seconds. The GSL is a non-exhaustive list meaning it will be always opened for the particular agenda till the relevant matters are conducted and suspended. If the delegate giving the speech has

more than 10 seconds remaining in their allotted time, then they may choose to yield their remaining time. This can be done in the following ways:

1. **Yield to the floor:** The remaining time is opened to the floor whereby questions or comments may be addressed to the delegates.
2. **Yield to the dais:** The remaining time is conceded to the dais who will suspend the remaining time and head to the next speaker on the list.
3. **Yield to the next speaker:** The remaining time is conceded to the immediate next speaker on the list.

Only once a motion is passed to move to another stage of debate, the committee proceeds accordingly.

Motions

Delegates may introduce motions to structure debate, such as moderated and unmoderated caucuses, extensions, or moving to voting procedures. There is a prescribed language for a motion to be raised which goes along the lines of:

“The Delegate of _____ would like to raise a motion to set the agenda of the committee on _____.”

Though there can be many types of motions (motion to set the agenda or suspend formal session for example), the most common motions are:

1. **Motion for a Moderated Caucus**
A structured discussion on a specific aspect of the topic, with delegates speaking in a timed format. Here the sub-topic for discussion must be mentioned, along with the total time and per-speaker-time in a structured manner.

“The Delegate of _____ would like to raise a motion for a Moderated Caucus on the topic ‘_____’ for a total time of ‘___’ minutes with each delegate _____ getting ‘____’ seconds.”

2. **Motion for an Unmoderated Caucus:** A suspension of formal debate, allowing delegates to discuss informally and draft resolutions. Only total time is specified in this motion.

Motion hierarchy depends on **Order of Disruption** whereby the motion that entertains the most number of speakers takes precedence. Meaning that even if a motion is raised after another delegate, if it entertains more delegates will be voted on by the committee first.

Points, Pleas and Rights
Delegates may raise points, which are special privileges afforded to delegates. They convey intent of

the delegates to other delegates or the dais. Points may only be addressed if delegates are recognized by the dais. such as:

1. **Point of Personal Privilege:** Used to address personal discomfort affecting participation (e.g., inability to hear the speaker).
2. **Point of Order:** Raised when a delegate believes the Chair has made a procedural mistake.
3. **Point of Parliamentary Inquiry:** Used to ask the Chair about procedural matters.
4. **Point of Information:** Used to ask questions or provide a comment to another delegate's speech. This can only be exercised if the delegate yields to the floor.

This is where there is a lot of difference. Namely in the following:

1. **Plea to Reply:** Raised by delegates to answer a Point of Information raised to them
2. **Plea to Follow Up:** Raised by delegates to ask another question after a reply has been provided. This can be circumvented through a plea to answer via chit.

Following this, a general question answer format would generally be:

1. **Point of Information** - by delegate wishing to ask a question
2. **Plea to Reply** - by delegate to whom the question is raised
3. **Plea to Follow Up** - by delegate wishing to ask a question
4. **Plea to Reply** - by delegate to whom is follow up is raised

Apart from this there is a caveat known as a Right, the only one that will be entertained is:

1. **Right of Reply:** In the case of sovereign or personal offence then delegates may raise this right to address serious breaches.

Voting

Procedures

The UN as a democratic organization operates in majority will. This applies to all procedures. When motions are raised then a procedural vote is required. The form for a procedural vote is held in two rounds, which can be understood as follows:

1. **Informal:** In this round only willing delegates may respond. It is created to ease voting matters in a committee. They are afforded with two options:
 - a. **Second the Motion:** Meaning that the delegate supports the presented motion. Note that conceptually this extends from the idea that "if that delegate had not raised it, I would have" meaning that the delegate who raises the motion cannot second their motion cannot second their own motion.
 - b. **Opposition to the Motion:** This means that the delegate does not support the motion. If even one delegate opposes a motion the formal proceedings.

2. **Formal:** In this round all delegates are required to vote. It is the actual voting where all votes are counted and a simple majority is needed for a motion to pass. If all motions raised fail then we recert back to the GSL, or in special conditions mandatory Unmoderated caucuses.
 - a. **For:** As indicated by its name, this is for support.
 - b. **Against:** As indicated by its name, this is for dissent.

Another form of voting occurs when debate on a resolution concludes, the committee enters voting procedures. During this time, no note-passing or speaking is allowed except for motions directly related to voting. All delegates must vote “Yes,” “No,” or “Abstain” (unless marked as “Present and Voting” during Roll Call). Most resolutions require a simple majority to pass, though certain actions, such as amendments or closing debate, may require a two-thirds majority. The voting requisites are met as follows:

1. **Simple Majority:** 50% +1
2. **Absolute Majority:** 2/3rds Majority (67%)

Closing **the** **Session**
Once all topics have been addressed and resolutions voted upon, the Chair may entertain a motion to close the session. If passed, the Chair will formally adjourn the committee, concluding its proceedings. This must be raised as a motion to either “**suspend formal session**” for breaks or “**adjourn committee session**” after the discourse on a set agenda has been exhausted.

Crisis Committee

Because this is a **Crisis Committee**, the committee will operate with the same formal-parliamentary baseline described above, **but with additional tools** that allow delegates to react to fast-changing events in real time. Unless otherwise stated by the dais (ergo ME), all Crisis tools are **subject to dais discretion** for reasons of realism, feasibility, and committee flow.

Crisis Update

In a Crisis Committee, there will be a or multiple ongoing crises (If it wasn’t already obvious). A **Crisis Update** is an official development announced by the dais that advances the crisis timeline, introduces new facts, or reflects the consequences of delegate action. In a Crisis Committee, Crisis Updates are the primary mechanism through which the dais simulates a living situation: events evolve, actors react, and decisions produce measurable outcomes. Crisis Updates are issued **at the sole discretion of the dais**. The dais may present an update at any moment, during the GSL,

during caucus, between motions, or immediately following a major committee action, when doing so improves realism, flow, or the strategic direction of debate.

Because each Crisis Update introduces a distinct immediate problem-set, the committee is expected to shift into focused discussion through a **Special Speakers' List (SSL)** tied to that update. Accordingly:

- After a Crisis Update, the dais will typically invite the committee to respond by **opening an SSL** on the new update, either **automatically** or **upon motion**.
- Delegates should treat the SSL as the procedural “bridge” between the update and crisis action, using it to stake positions, propose pathways, and signal intended Communiqués/Directives.

A major thing to note is that after each Crisis Update is presented before the committee, the delegates may request for clarification from the Crisis Director/Dais. Please note that this can only be done immediately after.

Special Speakers List

In a Crisis Committee, there will be moments when the committee must respond to a **specific urgent development** (a breaking update, a major incident, a sudden policy window, or a time-sensitive negotiation). For these moments, the dais may open a **Special Speakers' List (SSL)**. The SSL is used to concentrate debate on a narrowly defined crisis prompt. It is **separate from** the General Speakers' List (GSL), and it exists to ensure that urgent matters receive focused attention without disrupting the overall agenda structure. Therefore, you are expected to raise a Motion for one after each Crisis Update and is treated as non-exhaustive till the next crisis update is read out. A authority that delegates hold is that they may **specify the speaker time duration for the SSL** when raising the motion, **otherwise it defaults to 90 seconds**.

Communiqués

A **Communiqué** is a formal written message sent by a delegate (or multiple delegates) to an external actor or body in the crisis universe. It is used to **request information, convey a diplomatic message, seek consent, threaten consequences, propose negotiations, or coordinate with actors outside the room**.

Submission and approval:

- Communiqués must be written in clear diplomatic language and submitted to crisis staff/dais through the method designated by the chair (paper slips, crisis forms, or a digital system).

- All Communiqués are **subject to dais approval**. The dais may approve, modify, delay, partially approve, or reject a communiqué for realism, legality, feasibility, or committee balance.

Types of Communiqués:

1. **Open Communiqué:** The content is treated as public-facing (e.g., press statement, public diplomatic note).
2. **Closed Communiqué:** The content is treated as confidential and known only to the sender, the recipient, and the dais (e.g., backchannel negotiation, intelligence coordination).
3. **Joint Communiqué:** Multiple delegates co-sign a single message, indicating a coordinated position. Joint communiqués may be open or closed.

Directives

A **Directive** is a written order action that instructs the execution of a policy, operation, or administrative step. Unlike a communiqué (which communicates), a directive **does**. Directives must be **specific, actionable, and realistic** within the authority of the actor issuing them. If a directive assumes resources, jurisdiction, or consent that the issuing actor does not plausibly have, the dais may revise or reject it.

A. Individual Directives

An **Individual Directive** is submitted by a single delegate acting within their assumed authority. It represents unilateral action (e.g., domestic measures, executive instructions, border procedures, emergency deployments, administrative decisions). This is for individual action and can range from military conduct to thresholds for speed, clarity, and control without negotiating signatories.

B. Joint Directives

A **Joint Directive** is co-signed by multiple delegates. It represents coordinated action, burden-sharing, or a coalition posture (e.g., joint patrols, shared humanitarian corridors, coordinated sanctions, joint investigative task force). You may opt for it when you need legitimacy, combined resources, or a united front, and when implementation requires multiple actors.

C. Open Directives

An **Open Directive** is treated as public-facing and intended to shape public perception and international reaction. This can be outright military orders, public decree enforcement or even judicial conduct.

D. Closed Directives

A **Closed Directive** is confidential and intended to preserve deniability, protect sensitive operations, or conduct covert coordination (e.g., sensitive negotiations, intelligence operations, discreet resource transfers). All closed directives remain fully reviewable by the dais, and the dais may impose consequences if a closed directive would predictably trigger international backlash once discovered.

Committee Directive

Because this is a Crisis Committee, the committee may not always proceed through a long resolution-drafting process. Instead, the committee may adopt a **Committee Directive**, which functions as a **committee-level outcome document** and may serve as a practical substitute for a traditional resolution. A Committee Directive expresses the committee's collective decision(s) and authorizes committee-wide action. It is typically used when time is limited and the committee must produce **rapid, coherent policy outputs**.

Unless otherwise specified by the dais, a Committee Directive requires a **simple majority (50% + 1)** to pass. Abstentions follow the same rules described above (depending on "Present" vs "Present and Voting").

Once adopted, a Committee Directive becomes the committee's official policy output for that phase of the crisis. The dais may treat it as binding committee guidance and will simulate consequences, compliance, or backlash accordingly.

Annex III - Draft Document Formats

Communiqué

(Type of Communiqué) **COMMUNIQUÉ**
To: [Recipient name + title/organization] - [Committee]
From: Delegate of [Country] (Capacity: [office/role, if applicable])

Subject: [One-line purpose]

Message:

Requested

Response/Action:

Signatories:

[Name(s) of delegate(s)/country(ies)] (*if joint*)

Example

Closed COMMUNIQUÉ

To: Director

From: Niger Ministry of Food and Agriculture

Classification: Closed

Subject: Emergency food corridor and rapid needs assessment

Message:

Following the latest displacement surge, we request WFP's immediate support to establish a temporary food distribution corridor into Tillabéri. We can provide secure storage sites and local transport escorts coordinated through provincial authorities. Please indicate what minimum security assurances WFP requires and the earliest deployment window.

Signed by:

Minister of Food and Agriculture

Niger

Directive

(Type of Directive) **DIRECTIVE**
Title: [Action name in 3–8 words]
Submitted by: Delegate of [Country]
Objective: [One sentence: what this action achieves]

Operational Steps:

1. [Step 1, who does what]
2. [Step 2, where/when/how]
3. [Step 3, coordination/communications]

Resources/Authorities Assumed:

- [Units, funds, legal authority, personnel, logistics, keep realistic]

Timeline:

- Start: [immediate / within X hours/days]
- Duration: [X days/weeks or “ongoing until reviewed”]

Risks & Mitigation:

- *Risk: [key risk] → Mitigation: [how you reduce it]*

Signatories:

[Name(s) of delegate(s)/country(ies)] *(if joint)*

Example

OPEN DIRECTIVE

Title: Operation MARKET SHIELD

Submitted by: Delegate of Nigeria

Objective: Secure the movement, storage, and controlled release of emergency food stocks to stabilize staple prices in designated urban markets over 14 days.

Assuming the availability of 1 × [INF BN] for static and perimeter security tasks, 1 × [MP element] for access control and convoy discipline, 1 × [Logistics platoon] for movement coordination, and embedded liaison officers from the Police, NSCDC, Customs, the Ministry of Agriculture, and NEMA operating through the JCC. Equipment requirements are limited to committee-safe assets, including marked transport trucks, escort vehicles, standard communications kits, tamper-evident inventory seals, barriers for controlled perimeters, and basic medical and first-response capability sufficient for routine convoy and market-site support. Legal authority is derived from emergency administrative powers enabling the release of strategic reserves, lawful policing powers for investigation and enforcement, and a federal mandate authorising inter-agency operational coordination through the JCC. Logistical support will be provided through fuel allocation under emergency procurement mechanisms, secure staging sites at Nodes A and B, and the use of standardised manifests with serialised release forms to ensure end-to-end accountability from depot to market.

1. Assuming the availability of 1 × [INF BN] for static and perimeter security tasks, 1 × [MP element] for access control and convoy discipline, 1 × [Logistics platoon] for movement coordination, and embedded liaison officers from the Police, NSCDC, Customs, the Ministry of Agriculture, and NEMA operating through the JCC.
2. Immediately upon activation (T+0 to T+12 hours), [Designated Infantry Battalion (INF BN)] and [Military Police Company/Platoon (MP)] will deploy into AO ABUJA and AO KANO to establish a Joint Civil-Military Coordination Cell (JCC) with the Nigeria Police Force, NSCDC, Customs, the Ministry of Agriculture, and NEMA. Operating from [JCC Location: Government Complex/Operations Room], the JCC will function as the single coordinating authority for the operation, responsible for issuing movement tables, assigning liaison officers to each operational node, and maintaining a unified incident-reporting system. During this initial phase, the JCC will confirm priority commodities, verify approved distribution partners, and register all drivers and vehicles under a unified manifest regime using serialised release forms to ensure traceability from the outset.
3. Diversion, hoarding, or corruption may undermine distribution and weaken price-stabilization effects; this will be mitigated through sealed manifests, dual-signature release procedures, randomized inspections, and a case-tracked reporting channel routed through the JCC. Disorder at markets or disruption of convoy movement may delay deliveries and trigger panic buying; this will be mitigated through scheduled convoy windows, controlled perimeters at distribution points led by Police/NSCDC, and rapid-response inter-agency coordination through the JCC.

Signatories:

President of Nigeria
Nigeria